



SQF Food Safety Audit Edition 9

Once Again Nut Butter

Summary

AUDIT DECISION**CERTIFIED****CERTIFICATION NUMBER****6967 | 591694****AUDIT RATING****Excellent****DECISION DATE****05/24/24****AUDIT TYPE****RE-CERTIFICATION****RECERTIFICATION DATE****03/27/25****AUDIT DATES****04/16/24 - 04/18/24****EXPIRATION DATE****06/10/25****ISSUE DATE****05/24/24**

Facility & Scope

Once Again Nut Butter

12 S State Street
Nunida NY 14517
United States

Food Sector Categories:

14, 32

Products:

14. Fruit, Vegetable and Nut Processing, and
Fruit Juices :

Almonds, Almond Butter, Cashews, Cashew
Butter, Nut Butter, Peanuts, Peanut Butter,
Seeds, Seed Butter

32. Manufacture of Pet Food : Peanut Butter
Snacks

Scope of Certification:

Receival of ingredients, storage, roasting,
cooling, mixing, packaging and distribution of
nut products and pet food.

Certification Body & Audit Team

Mérieux NutriSciences Certification

401 N Michigan Suite 1400, Chicago, IL 60611 USA

CB#: CB-1-Mérieux

Accreditation Body: JAS-ANZ

Accreditation Number: Z3720906AB

Lead Auditor: Mark Weighner (10217)

Technical Reviewer: Ute Baker (9745)

Hours Spent on Site: 22

Hours of ICT Activities:

Hours Spent Writing Report: 8

2.6.3 Product Withdrawal and Recall (Mandatory)

The site conducted trace exercises and mock recalls at least once per year. The exercises included trace back to packaging, back to ingredients, and forward to shipping. The reports of the trace were recorded on a Recall / Withdrawal Form that tracked the item, lot code, duration, total to account for, total Not Accounted for, and details of Shipping Accounts (per potential storage location). Reviewed Mock Recalls from 2/16/24 (peanut butter forward) and 4/11/24 (drums going back to receipt).

Minor 2.6.3.2: A recent trace on fiber drums had listed a recovery rate as 399/399; however, records attached to the trace showed only 321 drums had been received and the records did not account for the excess drums.

- 2.6.3.2** The product withdrawal and recall system shall be reviewed, tested, and verified as effective at least annually. Testing shall include incoming materials (minimum one step back) and finished product (minimum one step forward). Testing shall be carried out on products from different shifts and for materials (including bulk materials) that are used across a range of products and/or products that are shipped to a wide range of customers.

RESPONSE: MINOR

EVIDENCE: A recent trace on fiber drums had listed a recovery rate as 399/399; however, records attached to the trace showed only 321 drums had been received and the records did not account for the excess drums.

ROOT CAUSE: Case was not created in SafetyChain to document the non-conformance.

CORRECTIVE ACTION: Complete Investigation on why the system tracked more drums than received.

VERIFICATION OF CLOSEOUT: Accepted, Mark Weighner

COMPLETION DATE: 05/09/2024 **CLOSEOUT DATE:** 05/12/2024

11.1.7 Equipment and Utensils

The General Manager worked with maintenance and had a list of design specification requirements (Equipment / Structure Fabrication Requirements) needed when purchasing or building equipment. Product design standards included stainless steel, COP wash-down, UHMW plastic, flexible vinyl conveyors, aluminum vacuum-transfer piping, and carbon steel (non-wash-down areas). QA maintained inspections on equipment installation and after repairs on the software program that was used. Regulatory design standards did not apply.

Tables, conveyors, tubs, and containers were designed, constructed, and installed to these same standards. The design and maintenance of the equipment prevented risks of cross-contamination. Equipment surfaces were smooth, impervious, and free from cracks and crevices. Bins and containers were made of non-toxic materials (Rubbermaid) and were color-coded for use. Fork trucks were electric. Maintenance was responsible for tagging out equipment found unfit for use with no equipment tag outs being observed during the audit.

Minor 11.1.7.4: A lid being used for the cashew pasteurizer hopper was observed with a closed-cell foam structure. A Lexan cover was used on the cashew mixer that was not secured away from the rotating shaft.

- 11.1.7.4** Product contact surfaces and those surfaces not in direct contact with food in food handling areas, raw material storage, packaging storage, and cold storage areas shall be constructed of materials that will not contribute to a food safety risk.

RESPONSE: MINOR

EVIDENCE: A lid being used for the cashew pasteurizer hopper was observed with a closed-cell foam structure.

A Lexan cover was used on the cashew mixer that was not secured away from the rotating shaft.

ROOT CAUSE: Lid for cashew hopper was in place and appeared to be an acceptable non-porous material. Follow Equipment and Utensil Specification Policy - QMS-PLC0080 and design new cover.

Production applied Lexan cover to decrease exposure from foreign material entering the product stream.

CORRECTIVE ACTION: Destroy current lid for cashew hopper. Cover bin with temporary cover.

Removed Lexan bin cover away from mixer during audit.

VERIFICATION OF CLOSEOUT: Accepted, Mark Weighner

COMPLETION DATE: 05/09/2024 **CLOSEOUT DATE:** 05/12/2024

11.2.1 Repairs and Maintenance

Maintenance was managed through a software program designed to manage maintenance activities. The software included the list of PMs that were due at any time. Work orders were provided with an expected due date and completed PM work orders regenerated themselves to the next due date based on the assigned frequency.

Maintenance was under the responsibility of the General Manager and maintenance completion/open activities were reviewed in weekly SQF meetings.

The process allowed anyone (supervisor or QA and above) to log in and request a work order.

The system in place for inspections on Priority 1 (food contact) after repair was to inspect the repair and record the inspection in the Quality Management Software.

Temporary repairs were allowed as long as they were logged into the maintenance repair log, they were not allowed to use unsafe materials (tape, wood, wire, cardboard, plastic), and they were fixed as soon as possible and tracked through the QA program.

Food grade and non-food grade lubricants were kept in separate cabinets and only food grade lubricants were used on production equipment. Product contact surfaces were not painted.

Minor 11.2.1.4: A requested repair on the squeeze pack line (maintenance work order 9258) stated the pump had to be disassembled and put back together correctly. The notification to the Production Supervisor and/or QA Supervisor was not recorded, and no Quality Management Inspection by QA had been completed during/after the repair, as required by the procedure.

- 11.2.1.4** Site supervisors shall be notified when maintenance or repairs are to be undertaken in any processing, handling, or storage areas.

RESPONSE: MINOR

EVIDENCE: A requested repair on the squeeze pack line (maintenance work order 9258) stated the pump had to be disassembled and put back together correctly. The notification to the Production Supervisor and/or QA Supervisor was not recorded and no Quality Management Inspection by QA had been completed during/after the repair, as required by the procedure.

ROOT CAUSE: No procedure established detailing the activities to be followed during Maintenance or Repair work in production areas.

CORRECTIVE ACTION: Zone 1 Maintenance Form - QMS-FORM0194 didn't include all Zone 1 areas. Roasters, Fillers, and Capper areas were the only areas included on the form. Update form to include all Zone 1 areas.

VERIFICATION OF CLOSEOUT: Accepted, Mark Weighner

COMPLETION DATE: 05/09/2024 **CLOSEOUT DATE:** 05/12/2024

11.2.4 Pest Prevention

Pest control was managed through a third party PCO - the contract was reviewed / signed annually (1/29/2024). Pest control at the three sites was managed under the same agreement and included weekly inspections, interior rodent traps, ILT checks, and pheromone checks. The plan included monthly exterior bait station treatments and as-needed exterior perimeter treatments. Documents reviewed in the Pest Logbook were the PCO Business License (8/31/2026), Certificate of Insurance (10/1/2024), Applicator License (4/21/2024), list of Authorized Products (1/29/2024), Pest Control Material Authorization for Organic Facilities (1/29/2024), and SDS for each approved chemical. The Device Map was reviewed annually (3/11/2024) and a Pest Sighting Log was maintained by the site.

Reviewed Pest Inspection Reports (printed hard copy) from 4/15/2024, 4/2/2025, 2/5/24, and 1/29/24 with the reports being signed by the SQF Practitioner. The report format included a Recommendations tracker - a recommendation on floor cracks were signed off by the PCO on 4/5/2024. The PCO provided a summary of each visit as the last decision in each report.

A PCO QA Audit was completed by the pest control management team on 3/18/2024. The audit included a site inspection and made no recommendations for changes. The Quarterly Pest Activity Trend Report was included at the back of the Logbook with trends within listed thresholds. The areas were observed clean and free of harborage during the audit.

The site maintained the list of observations on their QA software program and tracked them through to completion. Examples of Closed Cases were provided during the audit included sealing up cracks around inlet augers in the peanut facility. The site did not store pesticides.

Minor 11.2.4.2: A can of Raid was observed in a janitorial cabinet at the Perry warehouse.

- 11.2.4.2** Pest contractors and/or internal pest controllers shall:
- Be licensed and approved by the local relevant authority;
 - Use only trained and qualified operators, who comply with regulatory requirements;
 - Use only approved chemicals;
 - Provide a pest prevention plan (refer to 2.3.2.8), which includes a site map, indicating the location of bait stations traps and other applicable pest control/monitoring devices;
 - Report to a responsible authorized person on entering the premises and after the completion of inspections or treatments;
 - Provide regular inspections for pest activity with appropriate action taken if pests are present, and
 - Provide a written report of their findings and the inspections and treatments applied.

RESPONSE: MINOR

EVIDENCE: A can of Raid was observed in a janitorial cabinet at the Perry warehouse.

ROOT CAUSE: Training form didn't include any questions revolving around the use of pesticides in the facility.

CORRECTIVE ACTION: Removed can from facility.

VERIFICATION OF CLOSEOUT: Accepted, Mark Weighner

COMPLETION DATE: 05/09/2024 **CLOSEOUT DATE:** 05/12/2024

Section Responses

Audit Statement	Audit
SQF Practitioner Name	Name the designated SQF Practitioner RESPONSE: JACOB RAWLEIGH
SQF Practitioner Email	Email of the designated SQF Practitioner RESPONSE: JAKE@OANB.COM
Opening Meeting	People Present at the Opening Meeting (Please list names and roles in the following format Name: Role separated by commas) RESPONSE: MARK BRACE: GENERAL MANAGER / QA DIRECTOR, JACOB RAWLEIGH: SQF PRACTITIONER / QA MANAGER, ROBERT GELSER: PRESIDENT, ZACH TALLMAN: QA SUPERVISOR, RYAN NUGENT: MAIN FACILITY PLANT MANAGER, BEN LAWTON: PB FACILITY PLANT MANAGER, DAN PIJANOWSKI: PURCHASING DIRECTOR, MARK WEIGHNER: SQF AUDITOR
Facility Description	Auditor Description of Facility (Please provide facility description include # of employees, size, production schedule, general layout, and any additional pertinent details) RESPONSE: INGREDIENTS,

EVIDENCE: Once Again Nut Butter was established in 1976 and operated two (2) manufacturing facilities located in Nunda, NY with an off-site warehouse located in Perry, NY (20 miles away). The Main Facility produced FSC 14 roasted almonds & almond butter, roasted cashews & cashew butter, roasted seeds and sesame and sunflower seed butter, and boxed nuts (seasonal). The Main facility was approximately 32,000 sq. ft. and the layout included ambient docks, ambient warehouse, storage cooler for raw materials, an almond roasting room, an almond butter filling room, bulk roasting room (cashew), bulk nut room (for both almond and cashew), seed room (sesames and sunflower), two (2) wet rooms for equipment cleaning and a hot room for equipment drying. The facility was equipped with a Neo Pure system (peracetic acid) for cashew treatment prior to roasting as a Preventive Control. The Main Facility was older; however, had been updated in the past 15 years to include steel walls and epoxy-lined concrete floors and had been maintained in good condition.

The Peanut Facility was dedicated to the manufacturing of peanut butter and boxed peanuts under FSC 14 and FSC 32 (peanut butter labeled for domestic pets). Processes included receiving raw peanuts, cleaning, roasting and milling into peanut butter and spreads. The Peanut Facility was built in 2016, maintained in good condition with steel-lined walls and high ceilings designed for sanitation, and was approximately 40,000 sq. ft. (raw peanuts were segregated from the roasted peanut side). Peanut butter was packaged into jars, boxes, or cardboard barrels. The shipping dock area for finished goods and receiving of packaging material was segregated from the raw material receiving dock.

The off-site warehouse was approximately 52,000 sq. ft and was used for the storage of packaging material and finished goods. The warehouse had been converted from a two-story manufacturing building to a single floor warehouse and occupied over half of the building it was located in - the warehouse was observed well maintained with insulated and/or steel walls, a steel ceiling, and concrete floors in good condition. The corrective actions from the previous audit were shown to have been effectively implemented and verified to prevent recurrence. The quality management system has been upgraded to a software program where the majority of record-keeping and document control were captured electronically.

Closing Meeting

People Present at the Closing Meeting (Please list names and roles in the following format Name: Role separated by commas)

RESPONSE: MARK BRACE: GENERAL MANAGER / QA DIRECTOR, JACOB RAWLEIGH: SQF PRACTITIONER / QA MANAGER, CHAD DONOVAN: CFO, ROBERT GELSER: PRESIDENT, ZACH TALLMAN: QA SUPERVISOR, RYAN NUGENT: MAIN FACILITY PLANT MANAGER, BEN LAWTON: PB FACILITY PLANT MANAGER, DAN PIJANOWSKI: PURCHASING DIRECTOR, MARK WEIGHNER: SQF AUDITOR

Auditor Recommendation

Auditor Recommendation

RESPONSE: RECERTIFICATION AT THE E GRADE UPON COMPLETION OF APPROVED CORRECTIVE ACTIONS.

2.1.1 Management Responsibility

The Food Safety Commitment identified the site as "company owned" with a commitment to superior products for the customers. The policy specifically called out their commitment to food safety culture, to consistently meet customer requirements, to maintain a HACCP Food Safety Plan, meet the requirements of the SQF Code, use methods of root cause analysis to support continuous improvement, and to evaluate the performance through assessing compliance to food safety KPIs.

The policy had been reviewed/updated 1/10/2024 and signed by the President and the General Manager on 1/15/2024.

Food Safety and Staff Responsibility (1/11/2024) stated it was the responsibility of the SQF Practitioner to ensure employees were kept informed of their responsibilities and they should report any food safety or quality issue to their supervisor. The policy stated any employee had the authority to shut down the operation until product safety and quality were assured. Employees were re-trained annually in their food safety requirements.

Food Safety Goals included complaints ,0.15 CC / 10K pounds, Zero Recalls, and SQF Excellence ratings.

The QA Manager was the SQF Practitioner. Job Descriptions were provided that identified his responsibilities for managing the SQF Programs, managing the HACCP Plan, and managing meetings/communication between the site and management. The Quality Manual included HACCP Certificates, SQF Implementation, and PCQI Certification for both the SQF Practitioner and the back-up SQF Practitioner.

The back-up Practitioner was the Dir QA / General Manager. He was the on-site manager of the QA Department with responsibilities for company operations. Back-up for other managers was listed in the Organizational Chart. Food Safety Team Members were listed as part of the job descriptions.

QA was responsible for ensuring the training needs of the site were met.

This audit was not unannounced, and no blackout dates were identified.

2.1.1.1 Senior site management shall prepare and implement a policy statement that outlines at a minimum the commitment of all site management to:

- i. Supply safe pet food;
- ii. Establish and maintain a food safety culture within the site;
- iii. Establish and continually improve the site's food safety management system; and
- iv. Comply with customer and regulatory requirements to supply safe pet food.

The policy statement shall be:

- i. Signed by the senior site manager and displayed in prominent positions; and
- ii. Effectively communicated to all site personnel in language(s) understood by all site personnel.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

2.1.1.2 Senior site management shall lead and support a food safety culture within the site that ensures at a minimum:

- i. The establishment, documentation, and communication to all relevant staff of food safety objectives and performance measures;
- ii. Adequate resources are available to meet food safety objectives;
- iii. Food safety practices and all applicable requirements of the SQF System are adopted and maintained;
- iv. Staff are informed and held accountable for their food safety and regulatory responsibilities;
- v. Staff are positively encouraged and required to notify management of actual or potential food safety issues; and
- vi. Staff are empowered to act to resolve food safety issues within their scope of work.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 2.1.1.3** The reporting structure shall identify and describe site personnel with specific responsibilities for tasks within the food safety management system and identify backup for absence of key personnel. Job descriptions for the key personnel shall be documented.

Site management shall ensure departments and operations are appropriately staffed and organizationally aligned to meet food safety objectives.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 2.1.1.4** Senior site management shall designate a primary and substitute SQF practitioner for each site with responsibility and authority to:

- i. Oversee the development, implementation, review, and maintenance of the SQF System;
- ii. Take appropriate action to ensure the integrity of the SQF System; and
- iii. Communicate to relevant personnel all information essential to ensure the effective implementation and maintenance of the SQF System.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 2.1.1.5** The primary and substitute SQF practitioner shall:

- i. Be employed by the site;
- ii. Hold a position of responsibility in relation to the management of the site's SQF System;
- iii. Have completed a HACCP training course;
- iv. Be competent to implement and maintain HACCP-based food safety plans; and
- v. Have an understanding of the SQF Food Safety Code: Pet Food Manufacturing and the requirements to implement and maintain an SQF System relevant to the site's scope of certification.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 2.1.1.6** Senior site management shall ensure the training needs of the site are resourced, implemented, and meet the requirements outlined in system element 2.9 and that site personnel meet the required competencies to carry out those functions affecting the legality and safety of pet food products.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 2.1.1.7** Senior site management shall ensure the integrity and continued operation of the food safety system in the event of organizational or personnel changes within the company or associated facilities.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 2.1.1.8** Senior site management shall designate defined blackout periods that prevent unannounced re-certification audits from occurring out of season or when the site is not operating for legitimate business reasons. The list of blackout dates and their justification shall be submitted to the certification body a minimum of one (1) month before the sixty (60) day re-certification window for the agreed-upon unannounced audit.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

2.1.2 Management Review

The entire SQF programs were reviewed annually with Senior Management with the 2023 System reviewing 4/9/2024. The entire review comprised 63 pages on a PowerPoint presentation. Topics included food safety objectives, previous management review items, previous audit NC, continuous improvement action item plans, customer complaints/trends, document control / changes, foreign material control, GMP, HACCP updates, internal audit results, maintenance results, NC and Holds, pest control, trace/recall results, sanitation charts, EMP, specifications, supplier approval issues, training completion, waste, and utilities. Minutes from 3/19/2024 shadowed Food Defense, Food Fraud, and Site Security had been reviewed to senior management.

Weekly QA reports were sent weekly to the senior management group by the QA Director. Requested and reviewed Reports from Sept, Dec 2023, and Mar 2024 with topics including daily Line Audits, and Monthly GMP Audit findings, Sanitation Completion for each facility, EMP results, Pest Control findings, Open Pest Control Recommendations. HACCP Deviations / Updates, Audits, Holds, Foreign Material Findings, Open Supplier Issues, Complaints, open Document Reviews.

- 2.1.2.1** The SQF system shall be reviewed by senior site management at least annually and include:

- i. Changes to food safety management system documentation (policies, procedures, specifications, food safety plan);
- ii. Food safety culture performance;
- iii. Food safety objectives and performance measures;
- iv. Corrective and preventative actions, and trends in findings from internal and external audits, customer complaints, and verification and validation activities;
- v. Hazard and risk management system; and
- vi. Follow-up action items from previous management review.

Records of all management reviews and updates shall be maintained.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 2.1.2.2** The SQF practitioner(s) shall update senior site management on at least a monthly basis on matters impacting the implementation and maintenance of the SQF System. The updates and management responses shall be documented.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

2.1.3 Complaint Management

Complaints were targeted to be <0.15/10K products manufactured. The results of the 2023 measurements were 0.13. Complaints for 2024 were running at 0.09 through March.

Complaints were tracked on a software program that looked at Texture, Taste, Foreign Material, Black Specs, Burnt, Odor, Shells, Glass, Hair, Wood Rock, Plastic. Another chart was FM/ Product Group. Foreign Material by Sub-Category. Shells had the highest FM complaints. Reviewed randomly requested complaint (metal foreign materials), shell foreign materials, glass. Each had been fully investigated and resolved. An example of how shell complaints had been reduced in 2023 was shown due to the process the site initiated by introducing crunchies to the blends. Overall complaints have been shown to have been reduced for four consecutive years. Corrective actions and preventive measures were recorded in the software program.

- 2.1.3.1** The methods and responsibility for handling, investigating, and resolving food safety complaints from commercial customers, consumers, and authorities, arising from pet food manufactured or handled on-site or co-manufactured, shall be documented and implemented.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 2.1.3.2** Adverse trends of customer complaint data shall be investigated and analyzed and the root cause established by personnel knowledgeable about the incidents.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 2.1.3.3** Corrective and preventative action shall be implemented based on the seriousness of the incident and the root cause analysis as outlined in 2.5.3. Records of customer complaints, their investigation, and resolution shall be maintained.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

2.2.1 Food Safety Management

The food safety management system was documented and maintained in an electronic format and included the site's food safety plan, quality plan, GMPs and prerequisite programs, and quality management systems required by SQF Module 2. Written programs were required to be reviewed, updated, signed and provided electronically to supervisors and managers as needed. Changes implemented that had an impact on the site's ability to deliver safe food were included in regular management meetings. The programs were provided electronically for the audit.

2.2.1.1	The methods and procedures the site uses to meet the requirements of the SQF Food Safety Code: Pet Food Manufacturing shall be maintained in electronic and/or hard copy documentation. It will be made available to relevant staff and include: i. A summary of the organization's food safety policies and the methods it will apply to meet the requirements of this standard; ii. The food safety policy statement and organization chart; iii. The processes and products included in the scope of certification; iv. Food safety regulations that apply to the manufacturing site and to the country of sale (if known); v. Raw material, ingredient, packaging, and finished product specifications; vi. Food safety procedures, pre-requisite programs, food safety plans; vii. Process controls that impact product safety; and viii. Other documentation necessary to support the development and the implementation, maintenance, and control of the SQF System. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT EVIDENCE:
2.2.1.2	Food safety plans, Good Manufacturing Practices, and all relevant aspects of the SQF System shall be reviewed, updated, and communicated as needed when any changes implemented have an impact on the site's ability to deliver safe pet food. All changes to food safety plans, Good Manufacturing Practices, and other aspects of the SQF System shall be validated or justified prior to their implementation. The reasons for the change shall be documented. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT EVIDENCE:
2.2.2	Document Control The Document Control program (#QMS-PRC0001) detailed the requirements of the SQF Practitioner in his responsibility to control forms and procedures that were made available for employees. No issues were noted with the documents reviewed and noted in the audit report. The site extensively used a QA Management software program that helped facilitate document review and accessibility to workers.
2.2.2.1	The methods and responsibility for maintaining document control and ensuring staff have access to current requirements and instructions shall be documented and implemented. Current SQF System documents and amendments to documents shall be maintained. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT EVIDENCE:

2.2.3 Records

Most forms were captured/verified electronically. 14 forms were listed as part of the electronic daily record verification (Metal Detector, Process Control Check, Pre-Op Audit Form, Bulk Weight Checks, Roaster Form - North, Roaster Form - South). QA had responsibility to conduct an electronically captured verification Line Check that ensured the product checks were being completed, as required (the Line Check was a separate electronic form). The electronic form-builder included evidence that each of the verified checks was completed. A further sort showed any failures that had occurred on any checks (high-lighted in red) to facilitate verification. The person verifying each record had to electronically sign in and the verification time was stamped. Lot code and label verification checks included a picture of the Work Order that was provided (this included information on the lot codes and labeling instructions that were supposed to be placed on finished products) and pictures of the actual labeled jars/pails/trays of finished products.

The QA Manager had responsibility to review the QA Line Audits each day, review any GMP deviations, review inspections and Glass/Brittle Plastic checks from each day.

Dates of records chosen for review were April 1-3, 2024, Jan 9-11, 2024, and Oct 18-20, 2024. Records and reviews appeared current and complete.

- 2.2.3.1** The methods, frequency, and responsibility for verifying, maintaining, and retaining records shall be documented and implemented.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 2.2.3.2** All records shall be legible and confirmed by those undertaking monitoring activities that demonstrate inspections, analyses, and other essential activities that have been completed.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 2.2.3.3** Records shall be readily accessible, retrievable, and securely stored to prevent unauthorized access, loss, damage, and deterioration. Retention periods shall be in accordance with customer, legal, and regulatory requirements, at minimum the product shelf-life or established by the site if no shelf-life exists.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

2.3.1 Product Formulation and Realization

R&D was responsible for the development of new products. New products had to be approved by QA and Operations as part of final approval. Requested the most recent approved product (Honey Peanut Butter - Industrial 480# drum). New product development was tracked on an ICN form - approvals included specifications, labels, HACCP, SQF, Kosher, Formulation Approval, Production Approval. The site holds monthly ICN meetings to track approvals.

Shelf life was based on historical evidence. Retention samples were maintained on each finished product for the shelf life and randomly evaluated for appearance, taste, and microbiological activity.

Changes to any formulation or ingredients were included in weekly food safety meetings that were led by the SQF Practitioner. Processes in place to prevent cross-contamination (peanut only facility, peanut free facility, and product specific rooms) were maintained when new products were tested/evaluated.

- 2.3.1.1** The methods and responsibility for designing and developing new product formulations and converting product concepts to commercial realization shall be documented and implemented.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 2.3.1.2** New product formulations, manufacturing processes, and the fulfillment of product requirements shall be established, validated, and verified by site trials and product testing as required to ensure product safety. Product formulations shall be developed by authorized persons to ensure that they meet the intended use, including minimum and maximum nutrient and medicinal values (e.g. vitamin D, thiamine, life stages, species, animal size, and or breeds).

Where necessary shelf life trials shall be conducted to establish and validate a new product's:

- i. Preparation, handling, and storage requirements including the establishment of "best before dates"; and
- ii. Microbiological criteria.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 2.3.1.3** A food safety plan shall be validated and verified by the site food safety team for each new product and its associated process through conversion to commercial production and distribution, or where a change to ingredients, process, or packaging occurs that may impact food safety.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 2.3.1.4** Product formulations and manufacturing processes for products included in the scope of certification shall be reviewed when there are changes in materials, ingredients, or equipment.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 2.3.1.5** The process flows for all new and existing manufacturing processes shall be designed to ensure that product is manufactured to approved product formulations and to prevent cross-contamination.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 2.3.1.6** Records of product design, formulations, label compliance, process flows, shelf life trials, and approvals for all new and existing products shall be maintained.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

2.3.2 Specifications (Raw Material, Packaging, Finished Product and Services)

Raw materials, including ingredients and packaging, were required to comply with the site's and customers' specifications. Materials were not received from other sites under the same corporate ownership. Letters of guarantee (LOG) and Certificates of Analysis were provided by almond and cashew suppliers to ensure product safety was not compromised and the received materials were fit for their intended purpose. Certificates of Conformance for packaging included confirmation that direct food contact packaging met regulatory and/or the approval criteria. Organic suppliers were required to provide evidence of organic compliance. Approved raw materials suppliers were required to notify the site's Quality department thirty (30) days in advance of changes in product composition that could impact product formulation.

Reviewed specifications associated with the last new product (dried honey) and the product chosen for trace (almonds, glass jars). The information was uploaded into the Software Program that was used for gathering records. The new ERP System included approved formulas and the list of Approved Suppliers for each ingredient. Packaging was verified for the glass jars and fiber drums. Each of these had specifications on file and each of the suppliers provided a Letter of Guarantee.

Description of services for contract service providers that had an impact on product safety were documented, current, included a full description of the services to be provided, and detailed relevant training requirements of contract personnel required to visit the site.

Current lists of the raw material, finished product, and contract service provider specifications were documented and maintained. Raw material specifications were maintained electronically in the ERP System.

- 2.3.2.1** The methods and responsibility for developing, managing, and approving raw material, finished product, and packaging specifications shall be documented.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 2.3.2.2** Specifications for all raw materials and packaging, including, but not limited to, ingredients, additives, hazardous chemicals, processing aids, and packaging that impact finished product safety shall be documented and kept current.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 2.3.2.3** All raw materials, packaging, and ingredients, including those received from other sites under the same corporate ownership, shall comply with specifications and with the relevant legislation in the country of manufacture and country of destination, if known.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 2.3.2.4** Raw materials, packaging, and ingredients shall be validated to ensure product safety is not compromised and the material is fit for its intended purpose.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

2.3.2.5 Site management shall require approved raw materials suppliers to notify the site of changes in product composition that could have an impact on product formulation (e.g. protein content, moisture, amino acid profiles, contaminant levels, tolerance levels, and/or other parameters that may be variable by crop or by season).

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

2.3.2.6 Verification of packaging shall include:

i. Certification that all packaging that comes into direct contact with pet food meets either regulatory acceptance or approval criteria. Documentation shall either be in the form of a declaration of continued guarantee of compliance, a certificate of conformance, or a certificate from the applicable regulatory agency.

ii. In the absence of a certificate of conformance, certificate of analysis, or letter of guarantee, tests and analyses shall be conducted and records maintained to confirm the absence of potential chemical migration from the packaging to the pet food contents.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

2.3.2.7 Finished product labels shall be accurate, comply with the relevant legislation, and be approved by qualified company personnel.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

2.3.2.8 Description of services for contract service providers that have an impact on product safety shall be documented, current, include a full description of the service to be provided, and detail relevant training requirements of all contract personnel.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

2.3.2.9 Finished product specifications shall be documented, current, approved by the site and their customer, accessible to relevant staff, and shall include, where applicable:

- i. Microbiological, chemical, and physical limits;
- ii. Composition to meet label claims;
- iii. Labeling and packaging requirements; and
- iv. Storage conditions.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

2.3.2.10 Specifications for raw materials and packaging, chemicals, processing aids, contract services, and finished products shall be reviewed as changes occur that impact product safety. Records of reviews shall be maintained.

A list of all the above specifications shall be maintained and kept current.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

2.3.3 Contract Manufacturers

Contract manufacturers were not utilized.

2.3.4 Approved Supplier Program

Approved suppliers were managed through the site's electronic software program. This program included a summary sheet (list of suppliers and products). The primary requirement for suppliers was a third-party GFSI Certificates - other criteria specific to each supplier were listed on the supplier file. Supplier files included details of contact information for each supplier, including emergency contact. The approval and monitoring were under the responsibility of the SQF Practitioner.

QA maintained a Supplier CAR Registry - reviewed file for the past twelve months. Each of the identified issues had been closed out. The register included documentation of follow-up. The program was maintained on an excel file and appeared current.

Management was able to provide evidence of CAPA from a label printer issue (this included a supplier audit by site management). Resolution of the CAPA as signed by the senior management team that participated in the audit.

As part of the initial approval, suppliers were required to complete a detailed supplier questionnaire and to provide a signed Letter of Guarantee. Emergency suppliers would be required to complete the minimum requirements listed in the approved supplier program; currently, the site had a back-up listed in the approval process for each material purchased.

Supplier audits were the responsibility of the General Manager and conducted as needed based on risk.

- 2.3.4.1** The responsibility and procedure for selecting, evaluating, approving, and monitoring an approved supplier shall be documented and implemented.

A current record of approved suppliers, receiving inspections, and supplier audits shall be maintained.

Code Amendment #2

Approved supplier registers shall include supplier contact details. All approved and emergency suppliers shall be registered.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 2.3.4.2** The approved supplier program shall be based on the prior performance of a supplier and the risk level of the raw materials ingredients, processing aids, packaging, and services supplied, and shall contain at a minimum:

- i. Agreed specifications (refer to 2.3.2);
- ii. Reference to the level of risk applied to a raw material, ingredients, packaging, services and the approved supplier;
- iii. A summary of the food safety controls implemented by the approved supplier;
- iv. Methods for granting approved supplier status;
- v. Methods and frequency of monitoring approved suppliers;
- vi. Details of the certificates of conformance if required; and
- vii. Methods and frequency of reviewing approved supplier performance and status.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

2.3.4.3 Verification of raw materials shall include certificates of conformance, certificate of analysis, or sampling and testing. The verification frequency shall be identified by the site.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

2.3.4.4 The receipt of raw materials, ingredients, processing aids, and packaging from non-approved suppliers shall be acceptable only in an emergency situation and provided a receipt inspection or analysis is conducted and recorded before use.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

2.3.4.5 Raw materials, ingredients, and packaging received from other sites under the same corporate ownership shall be subject to the same specification requirements (refer to 2.3.2), approved supplier requirements, and receipt inspections as all other material providers.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

2.3.4.6 Supplier audits shall be based on risk (as determined in 2.3.4.1) and shall be conducted by individuals knowledgeable of applicable regulatory and food safety requirements and trained in auditing techniques.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

2.4.1 Food Legislation

Food Legislation (QMS-PLC0022) detailed the relevant legislative requirements that the site was required to comply with. No regulatory warning/event had been issued to/occurred at the company since the previous recertification audit. QMS-PRC0054 detailed the methods and responsibility for ensuring the site was kept informed of legislative changes, scientific and technical developments, emerging food safety issues, and relevant industry codes of practice. The site's FDA Registration was verified to have been updated and valid through 12/31/2024.

The SOP included a statement that SQFI and the CB would be notified within 24 hours in the event of public notification requirements.

2.4.1.1 The site shall ensure that, at the time of delivery to its customer, the pet food supplied shall comply with the legislation that applies to the pet food and its production in the country of manufacturer and the country of use or sale (if known). This includes compliance with legislative requirements applicable to maximum residue limits, food safety, packaging, product description, net weights, labelling, nutritional requirements for the animal species, feeding guidance, the life stage and any other criteria listed under pet food legislation, and to relevant established industry codes of practice.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

2.4.1.2 The methods and responsibility for ensuring the site is kept informed of changes to relevant legislation, scientific and technical developments, emerging food safety issues, and relevant industry codes of practice shall be documented and implemented.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 2.4.1.3** SQFI and the certification body shall be notified in writing within twenty-four (24) hours as a result of a regulatory warning or event. Notification to SQFI shall be by email to foodsafetycrisis@sqfi.com.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

2.4.2 Good Manufacturing Practices

Each GMP was evaluated/summarized in a senior management review that was conducted annually. The GMPs required as part of Modules 4 and 11 were appropriately applied. The site had not requested nor been granted an exemption for any of the GMP requirements of the SQF Food Safety Code. The GMPs applicable to the scope of certification that outlined how food safety was controlled and assured were documented and implemented.

- 2.4.2.1** The site shall ensure the applicable Good Manufacturing Practices described in Module 4 of this Food Safety Code are applied or exempted according to a written risk analysis outlining the justification for exemption or evidence of the effectiveness of alternative control measures to ensure that food safety is not compromised.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 2.4.2.2** The Good Manufacturing Practices applicable to the scope of certification that outline how food safety is controlled and assured shall be documented and implemented.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

2.4.3 Food Safety Plan

The site had 6 product descriptions: Bulk Tree Nuts & Seeds, Dry Roasted Peanuts, Peanut Butter, Peanut Butter for Pets, Seed Butter, Tree Nut Butter. Each Product Description page included the Product name, Process Type (roasted, fried), Product description (safety characteristics aW <0.85), Ingredients, Packaging (poly packs, jars, plastic pails, cardboard tote with poly line, fiber drums), Intended Use (RTE or as ingredient for further manufacturing), Intended Use (General Public), Labeling (allergens), Storage Distribution (ambient), Shelf Life, and Approval. Examples of product descriptions reviewed included Peanut Butter (2/9/2024), Seed Butter (sunflower or sesame - 2/9/2024), Peanut Butter for Pets (2/9/2024).

Ingredients cashews, sunflower, peanuts were received as raw materials and required Roasting as a CCP prior to blending. Other tree nuts were received with a pasteurized COA and controlled the risk as a Supplier Preventive Control.

The Food Safety Plan had 11 Flow Diagrams. The flow diagrams were specific to rooms being manufactured and types of products being made. Flow Diagrams included utility inputs (compressed air), receipt of raw materials (peanuts), magnets, receipt of ingredients and packaging, blanching, blending, milling, chilling, addition of crunch, critical control points (roasting, glass cleaning, metal detection), and where waste was removed. Flow diagrams for peanut butter (2/17/2024), Almond Butter (2/17/2024), Rework (2/18/2024), and Receiving / Storage HACCP Flow (2/17/2024). Flow diagrams were signed/verified by the QA Manager and Director QA. Each Flow Diagram included a Risk Assessment, plus an additional risk assessment for the raw materials. Reviewed the PB Risk Assessment (3/26/2024), Boxed Tree Nut Seeds, Almond Room Risk Assessment (3/25/2024),

Hazards considered included Salmonella, Allergens, Mislabeling, Aflatoxins, Foreign Materials. Risks were determined by listed LxS that provided a FSRAM Score. Scores that were below 14 required the control to be a Preventive Control - justification was required on the risk assessment template. Risk assessments appeared complete and relevant to the site's risk.

CCPs were peanut roasting, tree nut/seed roasting, metal detection, and glass jar cleaning. Other Preventive Controls listed were pasteurized nut receiving, allergen labeling, sanitation, and allergen change-over. Records for each were provided during the audit.

CCP Summaries (12/4/2023) included each process control critical limit, monitoring steps, corrective actions (go

- 2.4.3.1** A food safety plan shall be prepared in accordance with the twelve steps identified in the Codex Alimentarius Commission HACCP guidelines. The food safety plan shall be effectively implemented and maintained and outline the means by which the site controls and assures food safety of the products or product groups included in the scope of the SQF certification and their associated processes. More than one HACCP food safety plan may be required to cover all products included in the scope of certification.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 2.4.3.2** The food safety plan or plans shall be developed and maintained by a multidisciplinary team that includes the SQF practitioner and those site personnel with technical, production, and engineering knowledge of the relevant products and associated processes. Where the relevant expertise is not available on-site, advice may be obtained from other sources to assist the food safety team. In the event external sources are used, the overall responsibility of the HACCP food safety plan shall remain with on-site personnel.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 2.4.3.3** The scope of each food safety plan shall be developed and documented including the start and endpoint of the processes under consideration and all relevant inputs and outputs.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

2.4.3.4 Product descriptions shall be developed and documented for all products included in the scope of the food safety plans. This shall reference the finished product specifications (refer to 2.3.2.9) plus any additional information relevant to product safety, such as pH, water activity, and/or composition.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

2.4.3.5 The intended use and reasonably foreseeable unintended use of each product shall be determined and documented by the food safety team. This shall include target pet groups, life stage, and level of activity, requirements for further processing if applicable, and potential alternative use of the product.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

2.4.3.6 The food safety team shall develop and document a flow diagram covering the scope of each food safety plan. The flow diagram shall include every step in the process, all raw material, packaging material, service inputs (e.g. water, steam, gasses as appropriate), scheduled process delays, and all process outputs including waste and rework. Each flow diagram shall be confirmed by the food safety team during all stages and hours of operation.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

2.4.3.7 The food safety team shall identify and document all food safety hazards that can reasonably be expected to occur at each step in the processes, including raw materials and other inputs.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

2.4.3.8 The food safety team shall conduct a hazard analysis for every identified hazard to identify which hazards are significant, i.e., their elimination or reduction to an acceptable level is necessary to ensure food safety. The methodology for determining hazard significance shall be documented and used consistently to assess all potential hazards.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

2.4.3.9 The food safety team shall determine and document the control measures that must be applied to all significant hazards. More than one control measure may be required to control an identified hazard, and more than one significant hazard may be controlled by a specific control measure.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

2.4.3.10 Based on the results of the hazard analysis (refer to 2.4.3.8), the food safety team shall identify the steps in the process where control must be applied to eliminate a significant hazard or reduce it to an acceptable level (i.e., a critical control point, or CCP). In instances where a significant hazard has been identified at a step in the process, but no control measure exists, the food safety team shall modify the process to include an appropriate control measure.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

2.4.3.11 For each identified CCP, the food safety team shall identify and document the limits that separate safe from unsafe product. The food safety team shall validate the critical limits to ensure the designated level of control of the identified food safety hazard(s) and that all critical limits and control measures individually or in combination effectively provide the level of control required (refer to 2.5.1.1).

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

2.4.3.12 The food safety team shall develop and document procedures to monitor CCPs to ensure they remain within the established limits (refer to 2.4.3.11). Monitoring procedures shall identify the personnel assigned to conduct testing, the sampling and test methods, and the test frequency.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

2.4.3.13 The food safety team shall develop and document deviation procedures that identify the disposition of affected product when monitoring indicates a loss of control at a CCP. The procedures shall also prescribe actions to correct the process step to prevent recurrence of the safety failure.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

2.4.3.14 The documented and approved food safety plan(s) shall be implemented in full. The effective implementation shall be monitored by the food safety team, and a full review of the documented and implemented plans shall be conducted at least annually, or when changes to the process, equipment, inputs, or other changes affecting product safety occur.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

2.4.3.15 Procedures shall be in place to verify that critical control points are effectively monitored and appropriate corrective actions are applied. Implemented food safety plans shall be verified as part of SQF System verification (refer to 2.5).

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

2.4.3.16 Critical control point monitoring, corrective action, and verification records shall be maintained and appropriately used.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 2.4.3.17** Where food safety regulations in the country of production and destination (if known) prescribe a food safety control methodology other than the Codex Alimentarius Commission HACCP guidelines, the food safety team shall implement food safety plans that meet both Codex and food regulatory requirements.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

2.4.4 Product Sampling, Inspection, and Analysis

Raw material (peanuts) sampling and testing was limited to aflatoxin. Pathogen testing was scheduled annually to verify the effectiveness of the pasteurization of the raw almonds. Whenever pathogen testing was conducted the products were held until results were reported.

In-process product testing included moisture, color, and grind size, removal torque for jar lids, and weight checks. Each packaging line had auto-samplers installed to pull samples equally from the entire production run. Finished product testing included peroxide, color, moisture, aerobic plate count (APC), coliforms, E. coli, yeast, mold, Salmonella, Listeria monocytogenes, and aflatoxin. A separate laboratory facility was located in an office building across the street from each production site. No microbiological analyses were conducted at the on-site lab. A proficiency testing program for aflatoxin testing had been developed and implemented quarterly. Results of proficiency were provided for the past year. Bio- hazardous waste was not collected. External 17025 laboratories are used to conduct environmental and product analyses. The laboratory was included on the site's contract service provider register.

Retention samples for raw materials (nuts and seeds) and finished products were in place. Raw material samples were retained for six (6) months after receipt and finished product samples were retained for the stated shelf life. Retention samples were stored ambiently, according to the typical storage conditions.

- 2.4.4.1** The methods, responsibility, and criteria for sampling, inspecting, and/or analyzing raw materials, work in progress, and finished product shall be documented and implemented.
The methods applied shall ensure that inspections and analyses are completed at regular intervals as required and to agreed specification and legal requirements.
Sampling and testing shall be representative of the process batch and ensure that process controls are maintained to meet specification and formulation.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 2.4.4.2** Product analyses shall be conducted to nationally recognized methods or company requirements or alternative methods that are validated as equivalent to the nationally recognized methods.
Where internal laboratories are used to conduct input, environmental, or product analysis, sampling and testing methods shall be in accordance with the applicable requirements of ISO/IEC 17025, including annual proficiency testing for staff conducting analyses.
External laboratories shall be accredited to ISO/IEC 17025 or equivalent international standard and included on the site's contract service specifications list (refer to 2.3.2.8).

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

2.4.4.3 On-site laboratories conducting chemical and microbiological analysis that may pose a risk to product safety shall be located separate from any pet food processing or handling activity and designed to limit access only to authorized personnel.
Signage shall be displayed identifying the laboratory area as a restricted area accessible only by authorized personnel.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

2.4.4.4 Provisions shall be made to isolate and contain all hazardous laboratory waste held on the premises and manage it separately from pet food waste. Laboratory waste outlets shall at a minimum be down stream of drains that service pet food processing and handling areas.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

2.4.4.5 Retention samples, if required by customers or regulations, shall be stored according to the typical storage conditions for the product and maintained for the stated shelf life of the product.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

2.4.4.6 Records of all inspections and analyses shall be maintained.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

2.4.5 Non-conforming Materials and Product

Hold Procedure of the Non-Conforming Products (2/20/2024) showed non-conforming products were under the authority of QA. The Hold Log has been transferred to the new ERP System and showed a couple pallets of glass jars were on Hold due to shipping damage (water). The previous Holds were managed on an excel file that was reviewed during the audit. Each of the Holds had been closed by QA, either released or destroyed.

2.4.5.1 The responsibility and methods outlining how non-conforming product, raw material, ingredient, work-in-progress, or packaging detected during receipt, storage, processing, handling, or delivery is handled shall be documented and implemented. The methods applied shall ensure:

- i. Non-conforming product is quarantined, identified, handled, and/or disposed of in a manner that minimizes the risk of inadvertent use, improper use, or risk to the integrity of finished product; and
- ii. All relevant staff are aware of the organization's quarantine and release requirements applicable to product placed under quarantine status.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

2.4.5.2 Quarantine records and records of the handling, corrective action, or disposal of nonconforming materials or product shall be maintained.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

2.4.6 Product Rework

The site only allowed rework when re-packaging peanut butter or nut butter in bulk fiber tubs (leakers). No other rework was allowed or used. Products with different lot codes were not mixed and the repackaged product maintained the lot code/shelf life of the previous packaging. Re-packaging drums were maintained on a separate excel file by QA.

2.4.6.1 The responsibility and methods outlining how ingredients, packaging, or products are reworked shall be documented and implemented. The methods applied shall ensure:

- i. Reworking operations are overseen by qualified personnel;
- ii. Reworked product is clearly identified and traceable;
- iii. Reworked product is processed in accordance with the site's food safety plan;
- iv. Each batch of reworked product is inspected or analyzed as required before release;
- v. Inspections and analyses conform to the requirements outlined in element 2.4.4.1;
- vi. Release of reworked product conforms to element 2.4.7; and
- vii. Reworked product does not affect the safety or integrity of the finished product.

Records of all reworking operations shall be maintained.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

2.4.7 Product Release

QA Supervisor / Manager were responsible for product release. Release criteria included it to be conducted by an authorized person, record reviews were completed and verified, verify no product had been placed on Hold, product testing data was recorded in lab book, and sensory analysis was completed.

A form had been created if QA was requested to ship the product prior to completion of test results though this was an infrequent request.

Each product line had auto-samplers; composites of each line each day were blended by QA and submitted daily. At a minimum, daily testing was completed for Sal (2-375 gm samples), Listeria (125 gm sample), APC, coliform, E. coli, Y&M, and Staphylococcus (25 gm sample). If customers had more stringent testing requirements, this information was provided to QA to ensure complete testing was done. Product testing was completed at a 17025 Laboratory. No finished product testing had failed product testing for the past year.

2.4.7.1 The responsibility and methods for releasing products shall be documented and implemented. The methods applied shall ensure the product is released by authorized personnel and only after all inspections and analyses are successfully completed and documented to verify legislative and other established food safety controls have been met.

Records of all product release shall be maintained.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

2.4.7.2 Product release shall include a procedure to confirm that product labels comply with the food legislation that applies in the country of manufacture and the country of use or sale, if known (refer to 2.4.1.1).

If product is packaged and distributed in bulk or unlabelled, product information shall be made available to inform customers and/or consumers of the requirements for its safe use.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

2.4.7.3 In the event that the site uses positive release based on product pathogen or chemical testing, a procedure shall be in place to ensure that product is not released until acceptable results have been received.
In the event that off-site or contract warehouses are used, these requirements shall be effectively communicated and verified as being followed.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

2.4.8 Environmental Monitoring

The risk based EMP program was under the responsibility of the SQF Practitioner and the Director QA. The EMP program required a minimum of 14 Salmonella and 4 Listeria sp. Tests to be conducted each week. QA had responsibility for swabbing and submitting products. The breakdown of testing was Zone 2 (50-60%), Zone 3 (30-40%), and Zone 4 (5-10%). The program referenced a site map that determined specific sites each week. Procedures required a positive to have vector swabs conducted, reclean the area, and follow-up swabbing in the same area (including vectors) for three weeks. The last swab that was positive was Salmonella in the raw side on a broom. Corrective actions had been completed and the case had closed out by Marc 30, 2023 with not follow-up findings.

2.4.8.1 A risk-based environmental monitoring program shall be in place for all food manufacturing processes and immediate surrounding areas, which impact manufacturing processes.
The responsibility and methods for the environmental monitoring program shall be documented and implemented.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

2.4.8.2 An environmental sampling and testing schedule shall be prepared. It shall at a minimum:
i. Detail the applicable pathogens or indicator organisms to test for in that industry;
ii. List the number of samples to be taken and the frequency of sampling;
iii. Outline the locations in which samples are to be taken and the rotation of locations as needed; and
iv. Describe the methods to handle elevated or undesirable results.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

2.4.8.3 Environmental testing results shall be monitored, tracked, and trended, and preventative actions (refer to 2.5.3.1) shall be implemented where unsatisfactory results or trends are observed.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

2.5.1 Validation and Effectiveness (Mandatory)

A Verification Schedule was documented that identified the procedures, frequency, and responsibilities for both Verification Activities and Validation Activities. The SQF Practitioner had primary responsibility for the Validation Activities and used the schedule to show these were completed.

Validation was completed for each of the CCPs (control points and critical limits). During the audit it was noted some of these validation signoffs were still in process (i.e. validation of incoming pasteurized nut products was still open due to not having yet received the results an validation of metal detectors was pending calibration and sign-off on all metal detectors (two different manufacturers). Validation on prerequisite control programs included waste, training, supplier approval, sanitation, maintenance, pest control, water, glass/brittle plastics, food fraud, food defense, complaints, and magnets. Validation consisted of a summary statement of effectiveness by the SQF Practitioner on each of these programs. The Validation process had last been updated/reviewed by the SQF Practitioner on 4/11/2024.

- 2.5.1.1** The methods, responsibility, and criteria for ensuring the effectiveness of all applicable elements of the SQF Program shall be documented, implemented, and effective. The methods applied shall ensure that:
- i. Good Manufacturing Practices are confirmed to ensure they achieve the required result;
 - ii. Critical food safety limits are reviewed annually and re-validated or justified by regulatory standards when changes occur; and
 - iii. Changes to the processes or procedures are assessed to ensure controls are still effective.
- Records of all validation activities shall be maintained.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

2.5.2 Verification Activities (Mandatory)

Verification responsibilities were embedded into the electronic document control software. Forms had been created that were labeled Required Verification. These forms (each check was a separate form) would automatically be emailed to QA management for verification. Any forms that had issues were highlighted in red to enable QA to review the entries in an effective manner. Additionally, QA had the responsibility to conduct daily line audits then the results of the QA Line Audit were emailed to the SQF Practitioner for verification for each line each day.

- 2.5.2.1** The methods, responsibility, and criteria for verifying monitoring of Good Manufacturing Practices, critical control points, and other food safety controls, and the legality of certified products shall be documented and implemented. The methods applied shall ensure that personnel with responsibility for verifying monitoring activities authorize each verified record.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 2.5.2.2** A verification schedule outlining the verification activities, their frequency of completion, and the person responsible for each activity shall be prepared and implemented. Records of verification of activities shall be maintained.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

2.5.3 Corrective and Preventative Action

Corrective Actions were a separate module in the electronic document software that was used. Incidents that incurred during the year were called cases and were tracked on a summary page. The procedure required CAPA for substantiated complaints, product defects, and non-compliance observations. Where required, CAPA was to include investigations and Root Cause Analysis (5-WHY was embedded in the software).

The program currently showed 5 open CAPA (sanitation failure, water back-up, COP chart failures, water sample high results, and identified plastic). The audit reviewed 3 examples of closed CAPA (roof leak, seed roaster early drop, and a cleaning validation failure).

Records of CAPA and root cause were presented in the completed software reports.

- 2.5.3.1** The responsibility and methods outlining how corrective and preventative actions are determined, implemented, and verified, including the identification of the root cause and resolution of non-compliance of critical food safety limits and deviations from food safety requirements, shall be documented and implemented. Deviations from food safety requirements may include customer complaints, nonconformances raised at internal or external audits and inspections, non-conforming product and equipment, withdrawals and recalls, as appropriate.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 2.5.3.2** Records of all investigation, root cause analysis, and resolution of non-conformities, their corrections, and the implementation of preventative actions shall be maintained.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

2.5.4 Internal Audits and Inspections

Internal Audit Procedure (4/14/2024) stated audits and inspections were recorded in the software program used for quality management by QA. The SQF Internal Audit was completed on an excel file using the SQF Checklist. The audit was conducted by the Dir. QA / General Manager. The internal audit report identified compliance as shading the current fields in green, leaving open items or future items in white, and highlighting any NC with Red font. Reviewed records of audits completed on different dates between 3/13/2024 and 4/3/2024 - the program was complete.

Management conducted monthly inspections, daily "high risk" inspections. The checklist for inspections included a check on Document Control, Personal Practices, General Practices, Tools, Ingredients/Packaging, Equipment, and Structure. Each categories included a list and instructions of what to check for in each area. Each inspection for each area was scored and reported to management. Inspections were completed by department managers. The inspection program was broken into 35 different areas (both manufacturing plants and the off-site warehouse). Results of inspections were quickly provided by the software, including results of scores and corrective actions. The audit reviewed a CAPA on a roof leak that had been resolved per the site's CAPA program (11/14/2023).

- 2.5.4.1** The methods and responsibility for scheduling and conducting internal audits to verify the effectiveness of the SQF System shall be documented and implemented. Internal audits shall be conducted in full and at least annually. The methods applied shall ensure:
- i. All applicable requirements of the SQF Food Safety Code: Pet Food Manufacturing are audited as per the SQF audit checklist or similar tool;
 - ii. Objective evidence is recorded to verify compliance and/or non-compliance;
 - iii. Corrective and preventative actions of deficiencies identified during the internal audits are undertaken; and
 - iv. Audit results are communicated to relevant management personnel and staff responsible for implementing and verifying corrective and preventative actions.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 2.5.4.2** Staff conducting internal audits shall be trained and competent in internal audit procedures. Where practical, staff conducting internal audits shall be independent of the function being audited.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 2.5.4.3** Regular inspections of the site and equipment shall be planned and carried out to verify Good Manufacturing Practices and facility and equipment maintenance are compliant to the SQF Food Safety Code: Food Manufacturing. The site shall:
- i. Take corrections or corrective and preventative action; and
 - ii. Maintain records of inspections and any corrective actions taken.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 2.5.4.4** Records of internal audits and inspections and any corrective and preventative actions taken as a result of internal audits shall be recorded as per 2.5.3.
Changes implemented from internal audits that have an impact on the site's ability to deliver safe food shall require a review of applicable aspects of the SQF System (refer to 2.3.1.3).

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

2.6.1 Product Identification

Operations had responsibility for ensuring raw materials, packaging, process aids (oils), and ingredients were labeled and tracked into production. Management had recently converted to a new ERP system where every component and finished product was scanned anytime they were manufactured and moved within the system. Requested receiving / lot tracking information on the Safflower Oil being observed used during the audit, this ingredient being chosen because it had been received prior to implementation of the new ERP system. Records quickly were provided to show the assigned lot (as labeled on the floor) was able to be tracked back to receipt of the ingredient on 5/22/2023. Paperwork included the approved COA that was received and the trailer inspection records.

Product start-up was tracked electronically - this process verified the correct component and lot codes being used. A shift change-over was demonstrated during the audit and observed that the operator used cameras to take pictures of production work orders, product labels, and printed lot codes as part of the completed checks.

- 2.6.1.1** The methods and responsibility for identifying raw materials, ingredients, packaging, work-in-progress, process inputs, and finished products during all stages of production and storage shall be documented and implemented to ensure:
- i. Raw materials, ingredients, packaging, work-in progress, process inputs, and finished products are clearly identified during all stages of receipt, production, storage, and dispatch; and
 - ii. Finished product is labelled to the customer specification and/or regulatory requirements.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 2.6.1.2** Product start up, product changeover, and packaging changeover (including label changes) procedures during packing shall be documented and implemented to ensure that the correct product is in the correct package and with the correct label and that the changeover is inspected and approved by an authorized person. Procedures shall be implemented to ensure that label use is reconciled and any inconsistencies investigated and resolved. Product changeover and label reconciliation records shall be maintained.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

2.6.2 Product Trace

The product chosen for trace during the audit was an almond crunchy manufactured on Jan 10. The site was asked to trace back to the receipt of the almonds (single ingredient) and the glass jars used in this product and forward it to shipping. Results of the trace were 2 hours 42 minutes to trace 4440 cases manufactured against 4440 cases produced. Trace went back to the lot code of the almond used, including the mass balance for the ingredient. Trace went back to the glass jars, including production records where lot codes were entered and the receiving paperwork with the packaging.

- 2.6.2.1** The responsibility and methods used to trace product shall be documented and implemented to ensure:
- i. Finished product is traceable at least one step forward to the customer and provides traceability at least one step back from the process to the manufacturing supplier;
 - ii. Includes date of receipt of raw materials, pet food contact packaging and materials, and other inputs;
 - iii. Traceability is maintained where product is reworked (refer to 2.4.6); and
 - iv. The effectiveness of the product trace system is reviewed at least annually as part of the product recall and withdrawal review (refer to 2.6.3.2).
- Records of raw and packaging material receipt and use and finished product dispatch and destination shall be maintained.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

2.6.3 Product Withdrawal and Recall (Mandatory)

The site conducted trace exercises and mock recalls at least once per year. The exercises included trace back to packaging, back to ingredients, and forward to shipping. The reports of the trace were recorded on a Recall / Withdrawal Form that tracked the item, lot code, duration, total to account for, total Not Accounted for, and details of Shipping Accounts (per potential storage location). Reviewed Mock Recalls from 2/16/24 (peanut butter forward) and 4/11/24 (drums going back to receipt).

Minor 2.6.3.2: A recent trace on fiber drums had listed a recovery rate as 399/399; however, records attached to the trace showed only 321 drums had been received and the records did not account for the excess drums.

- 2.6.3.1** The responsibility and methods used to withdraw or recall product shall be documented and implemented. The procedure shall:
- i. Identify those responsible for initiating, managing, and investigating a product withdrawal or recall;
 - ii. Describe the management procedures to be implemented including sources of legal, regulatory, and expert advice and essential traceability information;
 - iii. Outline a communication plan to inform site personnel, customers, consumers, authorities, and other essential bodies in a timely manner appropriate about the nature of the incident; and
 - iv. Ensure that SQFI, the certification body, and the appropriate regulatory authority are listed as essential organizations and notified in instances of a food safety incident of a public nature or product recall for any reason.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 2.6.3.2** The product withdrawal and recall system shall be reviewed, tested, and verified as effective at least annually. Testing shall include incoming materials (minimum one step back) and finished product (minimum one step forward).
- Testing shall be carried out on products from different shifts and for materials (including bulk materials) that are used across a range of products and/or products that are shipped to a wide range of customers.

RESPONSE: MINOR

EVIDENCE: A recent trace on fiber drums had listed a recovery rate as 399/399; however, records attached to the trace showed only 321 drums had been received and the records did not account for the excess drums.

ROOT CAUSE: Case was not created in SafetyChain to document the non-conformance.

CORRECTIVE ACTION: Complete Investigation on why the system tracked more drums than received.

VERIFICATION OF CLOSEOUT: Accepted, Mark Weighner

COMPLETION DATE: 05/09/2024 **CLOSEOUT DATE:** 05/12/2024

- 2.6.3.3** Records shall be maintained of withdrawal and recall tests, root cause investigations into actual withdrawals and recalls, and corrective and preventative actions applied.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 2.6.3.4** SQFI and the certification body shall be notified in writing within twenty-four (24) hours upon identification of a pet food safety event that requires public notification. SQFI shall be notified at foodsafetycrisis@sqfi.com.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

2.6.4 Crisis Management Planning

The Crisis Management Procedure (QMS-PRC0027) identified the roles and responsibilities for the Recovery Team members. The General Manager was identified as the senior manager responsible for decision making, oversight, and initiating actions arising from a crisis management incident.

Crisis Management test 3/19/2024 - desktop evaluation with the team on each step of the current plan with the changes documented and updated to the management review meeting.

The scenario of a Mock Crisis was a flood event that created back-up from the sewer into the facility - minutes were provided to show the actions taken by each member of the crisis team. The test was conducted the same day as the review of the entire program.

2.6.4.1

A crisis management plan based on the understanding of known potential dangers (e.g., flood, drought, fire, tsunami, or other severe weather events, warfare or civil unrest, computer outage, pandemic, loss of electricity or refrigeration, ammonia leak, labor strike) that can impact the site's ability to deliver safe food shall be documented by senior management, outlining the methods and responsibility the site shall implement to cope with such a business crisis. The crisis management plan shall include at a minimum:

- i. A senior manager responsible for decision making, oversight, and initiating actions arising from a crisis management incident;
- ii. The nomination and training of a crisis management team;
- iii. The controls implemented to ensure any responses do not compromise product safety;
- iv. The measures to isolate and identify product affected by a response to a crisis;
- v. The measures taken to verify the acceptability of food prior to release;
- vi. The preparation and maintenance of a current crisis alert contact list, including supply chain customers;
- vii. Sources of legal and expert advice; and
- viii. The responsibility for internal communications and communicating with authorities, external organizations, and media.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

2.6.4.2

The crisis management plan shall be reviewed, tested, and verified at least annually with gaps and appropriate corrective actions documented. Records of reviews of the crisis management plan shall be maintained.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

2.7.1 Food Defense Plan

The Food Defense Vulnerability Assessments (4/3/2024) was conducted annually. The sites were registered with the FDA Bioterrorism; the Peanut Facility and the Main site were under registration XXXXX9702, and the Perry Warehouse registration number was XXXXX3274. The site registration was valid through 12/31/2024. The US FDA Food Defense Plan Builder was utilized to conduct threat assessments and develop the Food Defense Plan for the Main Facility, Peanut Facility and the offsite Perry Warehouse. Instructions were provided to relevant personnel on the effective implementation of the food defense plans. The General Manager/QA Director was identified as the person having overall responsibility for food Defense. Key Activities and APS were based on FDA Intentional Adulteration Rules and evaluated ingredient feeders, oil pumps, mills, cashew pasteurization, and roasters. No APS was identified for the offsite warehouse. The Food Defense Challenge on 3/20/2024 involved a visitor who was not escorted by management. This test was conducted at each of the facilities and was deemed successful as the visitor was challenged/questioned by the first person he encountered.

- 2.7.1.1** A food defense threat assessment shall be conducted to identify potential threats that can be caused by a deliberate act of sabotage or terrorist-like incident.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 2.7.1.2** A food defense plan shall be documented, implemented, and maintained based on the threat assessment (refer to 2.7.1.1). The food defense plan shall meet legislative requirements as applicable and shall include at a minimum:
- i. The methods, responsibility, and criteria for preventing food adulteration caused by a deliberate act of sabotage or terrorist-like incident;
 - ii. The name of the senior site management person responsible for food defense;
 - iii. The methods implemented to ensure only authorized personnel have access to production equipment and vehicles, manufacturing, and storage areas through designated access points;
 - iv. The methods implemented to protect sensitive processing points from intentional adulteration;
 - v. The measures taken to ensure the secure receipt and storage of raw materials, ingredients, packaging, equipment, and hazardous chemicals to protect them from deliberate acts of sabotage or terrorist-like incidents;
 - vi. The measures implemented to ensure raw materials, ingredients, packaging (including labels), work-in-progress, process inputs, and finished products are held under secure storage and transportation conditions; and
 - vii. The methods implemented to record and control access to the premises by site personnel, contractors, and visitors.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 2.7.1.3** Instruction shall be provided to all relevant staff on the effective implementation of the food defense plan (refer to 2.9.2.1).

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 2.7.1.4** The food defense threat assessment and prevention plan shall be reviewed and tested at least annually or when the threat level, as defined in the threat assessment, changes. Records of reviews and tests of the food defense plan shall be maintained.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

2.7.2 Food Fraud

The food fraud risk assessment was reviewed on 3/20/24. The biggest risk with the incoming materials was organic. The original Food Fraud risk assessment was completed 2018 (PWC) and assessed substitution, finished product mislabeling, dilution, or counterfeiting. Annual reviews included the original assessment with notes from management (resource - Trello) each year on commodity and vendor issues noted worldwide. Mitigation on fraud was managed through the site's approved supplier program (letters of guarantee on file and COAs provided with materials at receipt) and organic certifier. No new risks to food fraud for the supplier foods had been identified since the last review.

- 2.7.2.1** The methods, responsibility, and criteria for identifying the site's vulnerability to food fraud, including susceptibility to raw material or ingredient substitution, finished product mislabeling, dilution, or counterfeiting, shall be documented, implemented, and maintained.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 2.7.2.2** A food fraud mitigation plan shall be developed and implemented that specifies the methods by which the identified food fraud vulnerabilities shall be controlled, including identified food safety vulnerabilities of ingredients and materials.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 2.7.2.3** Instruction shall be provided to all relevant staff on the effective implementation of the food fraud mitigation plan (refer to 2.9.2.1).

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 2.7.2.4** The food fraud vulnerability assessment and mitigation plan shall be reviewed and verified at least annually with gaps and corrective actions documented. Records of reviews shall be maintained.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

2.8.1 Allergen Management

Allergens included peanuts (peanut only facility), tree nuts (almonds, cashews), soy (soy sauce), and sesame. Everything post milling in both sites was wet cleaned and sanitation had been validated for allergen cleaning effectiveness. Dry mills and roasting were purged between changeovers. Mills and roasters that were changed to a new allergen required a detailed QA Inspection (electronic QA Management software) to ensure allergen cross-contamination was not at risk.

Allergen swabs for PB were completed after each wet clean. Allergen labeling was verified during the packaging by a label scan reader, if the wrong label was applied or a label was missed, the line would shut down. Product labeling was considered Preventive Control (verify labels by QA at receipt). Packaging lines used label reader/scanner to a barcode to ensure the right label was on the right product.

- 2.8.1.1** The responsibility and methods used to control human allergens (per country regulation) and to prevent sources of allergens from contaminating product shall be documented and implemented. The allergen management program shall include:
- i. A risk analysis of those inputs and processing aids, including food grade lubricants, that contain food allergens, and
 - ii. The hazards associated with allergens and their controls.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 2.8.1.2** Product labeling, in accordance with regulatory requirements, shall include allergens where risks from cross-contact have been identified.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

2.8.2 Label Claims

Label claims in place included RSPO, Non-Gluten, Organic, and Kosher. These were certified against third party requirements. Certificates were current and provided during the audit.

- 2.8.2.1** For products that are marketed as having limited ingredients (e.g., grain free, poultry free, etc.) the site shall ensure that:
- i. Raw materials, ingredients, and packaging are validated to make such claims;
 - ii. Product changeovers are validated and verified to ensure that the status of such claims is not compromised, and
 - iii. The system is effectively communicated to all applicable staff.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

2.9.1 Training Requirements

Training was divided into job training, Quality Management Training, Alchemy Training (annual refresher) and Group Training. Alchemy records were available electronically and required the employees to pass at >80% or retake the course. The training centers were provided in break areas.

HR and Safety Coordinator were responsible for ensuring safety training that tracked human safety and HR training. Chemical handling was trained in-house for each employee.

- 2.9.1.1** The responsibility for establishing and implementing the training needs of the organization's personnel to ensure they have the required competencies to carry out those functions affecting products, legality, and safety shall be defined and documented (refer to 2.1.1.6).

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 2.9.1.2** Appropriate training shall be provided for personnel carrying out the tasks essential to the effective implementation of the SQF System and the maintenance of food safety and regulatory requirements.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

2.9.2 Training Program

Annual refresher training for GMPs and Food Safety was managed as part of Alchemy and records were maintained in this system. The completion records were dated and included the result of each quiz associated with each course.

PowerPoint training was provided for Group Training, which was assigned for each group within the facility. CCP and Preventive Control Training (step-by-step) was an example of this type of training and was refreshed annually. Group training required a quiz as part of training completion. Examples of completed group training were provided and shown that this list was evaluated as part of ongoing review to ensure training was not being missed. Each operator had a listing of the SOPs each operator was trained in which included HACCP Refresher Training.

SSOPs were trained as part of Chemical Control in Alchemy; chemical handling, usage, and titration was trained by the Approved Chemical Provider each year. Training records were provided upon request and a training chart was provided that provided evidence the training program was current.

CCP training was included in the Quality Management system and verified employees were trained (including quizzes). Training reports were provided monthly to the SQF Group to track any open training that had been missed. Reports were shared with department managers to ensure training was not missed.

Completed training records included evidence of each trainee, the course name and description, completion (quizzes), and the trainers.

2.9.2.1 A training program shall be documented and implemented that outlines, at a minimum, the necessary competencies for specific duties and the training methods to be applied for personnel carrying out tasks associated with:

- i. Implementing HACCP for staff involved in developing and maintaining food safety plans;
 - ii. Monitoring and corrective action procedures for all staff engaged in monitoring critical control points (CCPs);
 - iii. Personal hygiene for all staff involved in handling of pet food products and pet food contact surfaces;
 - iv. Good Manufacturing Practices and work instructions for all staff engaged in pet food processes and equipment;
 - v. Sampling and test methods for all staff involved in sampling and testing of raw materials, packaging, work-in-progress, and finished products;
 - vi. Environmental monitoring for relevant staff;
 - vii. Food defense and food fraud for all on-site staff; and
 - viii. Tasks identified as critical to meeting effective implementation and maintenance of the SQF Code.
- The training program shall include provision for identifying and implementing the refresher training needs of the organization.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

2.9.2.2 Training materials, the delivery of training, and procedures on all tasks critical to meeting regulatory compliance and the maintenance of food safety shall be provided in languages understood by staff.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 2.9.2.3** Training records shall be maintained and include:
- i. Participant name;
 - ii. Skills description;
 - iii. Description of the training provided;
 - iv. Date training completed;
 - v. Trainer or training provider; and
 - vi. Verification that the trainee is competent to complete the required tasks.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

4.1.1 Premises Location and Approval

The site's buildings, property and surroundings were properly designed and maintained and were not observed to pose a risk to food safety. The Main Site (older, original site by the town center) and Peanut Facility Site (new building located in a residential area a few blocks away) were located in Nunda, NY. The sites were surrounded by homes or commercial businesses. The Perry Warehouse was half of a commercial building in a commercial lot located in a small town 25 minutes away. External areas were included in the site's internal inspection program. The sites were approved by the relevant authorities, as evidenced by city business licenses and verification of the current FDA Bioterrorism registrations.

- 4.1.1.1** The site shall assess local activities and the site environment to identify any risks that may have an adverse impact on product safety and implement controls for any identified risks. The assessment shall be reviewed in response to any changes in the local environment or activities.
- The construction and ongoing operation of the premises on the site shall be approved by the relevant authority.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

4.1.2 Building Materials

The design and maintenance of the manufacturing buildings met the high care requirements to mitigate food safety risks. Production and sanitation room floors at both sites were epoxy-coated, sanitation room floors were sloped to drains. Walls and ceilings at the peanut facility were steel panel or Insulated Steel Panels (ISP) and maintained in good condition. Upgrades to wall and ceiling rooms in the Main Site were noted from the previous year's audit (sesame roaster room). Other rooms were built as modular rooms with ISP panels. Floors were well maintained. The sanitation room drains were clean and in good condition. Rooms were segregated from other processing rooms and were dry-cleaned. Hand sinks were located at the entrance area to each room. Underground wastewater equalization tanks were used to collect wastewater prior to discharge to the city. Wall-floor junctions were designed to prevent build-up and noted as clean during the audit. Utility pipes were positioned away from direct contact from walls and ceilings and overhead equipment was maintained in good condition. Doors were of commercially designed materials and maintained to facilitate cleaning. Ceilings were clean and were not observed as a risk of potential contamination. Elevated processing platforms (blending) were designed not to present a risk of contamination; exposed products were not observed stored below stairs or ladders.

The site was not designed with sanitary waste lines located over processing or storage areas.

4.1.2.1 Floors shall be constructed of smooth, dense, impact-resistant material that can be effectively graded, drained, impervious to liquid, and easily cleaned. Floors shall be sloped to floor drains at gradients suitable to allow the effective removal of all overflow or wastewater under normal working conditions.
Where floor drainage is not available, plumbed options to handle overflow or wastewater shall be in place.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

4.1.2.2 Drains shall be constructed and located so they can be easily cleaned and not present a hazard.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

4.1.2.3 Waste trap system shall be located away from any pet food handling area or entrance to the premises.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

4.1.2.4 Walls, partitions, ceilings, and doors shall be of durable construction. Internal surfaces shall have an even and regular surface and be impervious with a light-colored finish and shall be kept clean (refer to 4.2.5).
Wall-to-wall and wall-to-floor junctions shall be designed to be easily cleaned and sealed to prevent the accumulation of pet food debris.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

4.1.2.5 Ducting, conduit, and pipes that convey services such as steam, water, or air shall be designed and constructed to prevent the contamination of pet food, ingredients, and pet food contact surfaces and allow ease of cleaning.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

4.1.2.7 Doors, hatches, and windows and their frames in pet food processing, handling, or storage areas shall be of a material and construction that meets the same functional requirements as for internal walls and partitions.
Doors and hatches shall be of solid construction and windows shall be made of shatterproof glass or similar material.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

4.1.2.8 Product shall be processed and handled in areas that are fitted with a ceiling or other acceptable structure that is constructed and maintained to prevent the contamination of products. Drop ceilings, where present, shall be constructed to enable monitoring for pest activity, facilitate cleaning, and provide access to utilities.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.1.2.9** Stairs, catwalks, and platforms in pet food processing and handling areas shall be designed and constructed so as not to present a product contamination risk, and with no open grates directly above exposed pet food contact surfaces. They shall be free from debris and maintained.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

4.1.3. Lightings and Light Fittings

Light fittings in the Main site and Peanut Facility site were high-efficient LED bulbs in shatter resistant fixtures and were observed clean and in good condition. Light intensity was appropriate for the processing, sanitation, and inspection activities. Light fixtures in the coolers and warehouse areas were the same design as in processing rooms. Lighting in the offsite warehouse was a combination of LED and florescent. Light fixtures were protected in shatterproof bulbs and fixtures. No issues were observed with broken/damaged light fixtures or with lights not working.

- 4.1.3.1** Lighting in pet food processing and handling areas and at inspection stations shall be of appropriate intensity to enable the staff to carry out their tasks efficiently and effectively.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.1.3.2** Light fixtures in processing areas, inspection stations, ingredient and packaging storage areas, and all areas where the product is exposed shall be shatterproof, manufactured with a shatterproof covering, or fitted with protective covers and recessed into or fitted flush with the ceiling.
Where fixtures cannot be recessed, structures must be protected from accidental breakage, manufactured from cleanable materials, and addressed in the cleaning and sanitation program.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.1.3.3** Light fixtures in the warehouse or other areas where product is covered or otherwise protected shall be designed such as to prevent breakage and product contamination.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

4.1.4 Inspection / Quality Control Area

Online inspections were not conducted. Packaging lines were equipped with auto-samplers and materials were removed from the floor prior to sampling / testing.

4.1.5 Dust, Insect, and Pest Proofing

The sites did not use windows or open ventilation in any process, packaging areas, or warehouse areas. External doors at each of the three sites were self-closing and observed in good condition. Seals around doors were close-fitting and prevented ingress. Dock cushions and overhangs were in place to seal around trailers while loading and unloading. ILTs were located away from storage or processing rooms. Rodenticide was not stored.

- 4.1.5.1** All external windows, ventilation openings, doors, and other openings shall be effectively sealed when closed and proofed against dust, vermin, and other pests.
External personnel access doors shall be effectively insect-proofed and fitted with a self-closing device and proper seals to protect against entry of dust, vermin, and other pests.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.1.5.2** External doors, including overhead dock doors in pet food handling areas used for product, pedestrian, or truck access, shall be designed and maintained to prevent pest ingress by at least one or a combination of the following methods:
- i. A self-closing device;
 - ii. An effective air curtain or air-flow device;
 - iii. A pest-proof screen;
 - iv. A pest-proof annex; and
 - v. Adequate sealing around trucks in docking areas.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.1.5.3** Electric insect control devices, pheromone, or other traps and baits shall be located and operate so as not to present a contamination risk to the product, packaging, containers, or processing equipment. Poison rodenticide bait shall not be used inside ingredient of product storage areas or processing areas where ingredients, packaging, and product are handled, processed, or exposed.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

4.1.6 Ventilation

Filtered HVAC ventilation systems (Merv 11) were in place for the processing (roasting and open product RTE) rooms to remove dust and debris from the processing and packaging areas. Ventilation equipment was clean and insect-proofed; filter replacement was included in the PM schedule. Extractor fans on roasters were appropriately designed and included in the master cleaning schedules. No condensation was observed in any of the roasters. Exhaust vents were screened to prevent insects from entering the facility when not in use.

- 4.1.6.1** Adequate ventilation shall be provided in enclosed processing and pet food handling areas.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.1.6.2** All ventilation equipment and devices in product storage and handling areas shall be adequately cleaned as per 4.2.5 to prevent unsanitary conditions.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.1.6.3** Extractor fans and canopies shall be provided in areas where open cooking operations are carried out or a large amount of steam is generated. Capture velocities shall be sufficient to prevent condensation build-up and to evacuate all heat, fumes, and other aerosols to the exterior via an exhaust hood positioned over the cooker(s).

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.1.6.4** Fans and exhaust vents shall be insect-proofed and located so as not to pose a contamination risk and be kept clean.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

4.1.7 Equipment and Utensils

The General Manager worked with maintenance and had a list of design specification requirements (Equipment / Structure Fabrication Requirements) needed when purchasing or building equipment. Product design standards included stainless steel, COP wash-down, UHMW plastic, flexible vinyl conveyors, aluminum vacuum-transfer piping, and carbon steel (non-wash-down areas). QA maintained inspections on equipment installation and after repairs on the software program that was used. Regulatory design standards did not apply.

Tables, conveyors, tubs, and containers were designed, constructed, and installed to these same standards. The design and maintenance of the equipment prevented risks of cross-contamination. Equipment surfaces were smooth, impervious, and free from cracks and crevices. Bins and containers were made of non-toxic materials (Rubbermaid) and were color-coded for use. Fork trucks were electric. Maintenance was responsible for tagging out equipment found unfit for use with no equipment tag outs being observed during the audit.

Minor 11.1.7.4: A lid being used for the cashew pasteurizer hopper was observed with a closed-cell foam structure. A Lexan cover was used on the cashew mixer that was not secured away from the rotating shaft.

- 4.1.7.1** Specifications for equipment and utensils and procedures for purchasing equipment shall be documented and implemented.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.1.7.2** Equipment and utensils shall be designed, constructed, installed, operated, and maintained to meet any applicable regulatory requirements and so as not to pose a contamination threat to products.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.1.7.3** Equipment storage rooms shall be designed and constructed to allow for the hygienic and efficient storage of equipment and containers. Where possible pet food contact equipment shall be segregated from non-pet food contact equipment.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

4.1.7.4 Product contact surfaces and those surfaces not in direct contact with pet food in pet food handling areas, raw material storage, packaging storage, and cold storage areas shall be constructed of materials that will not contribute to a food safety risk.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

4.1.7.5 Benches, tables, conveyors, mixers, mincers, graders, and other mechanical processing equipment shall be hygienically designed and located for appropriate cleaning. Equipment surfaces shall be smooth, impervious, and free from cracks or crevices.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

4.1.7.6 Product containers, tubs, and bins used for edible and inedible material shall be constructed of materials that are non-toxic, smooth, impervious, and readily cleaned as per 4.2.5.1. Bins used for inedible material shall be clearly identified.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

4.1.7.7 All equipment and utensils shall be cleaned after use (refer to 4.2.5.1) or at a set and validated frequency to control contamination and stored in a clean and serviceable condition to prevent microbiological or cross-contact allergen contamination.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

4.1.7.8 Vehicles used in pet food contact, handling, or processing zones or in cold storage rooms shall be designed and operated so as not to present a food safety hazard.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

4.1.7.9 Non-conforming equipment shall be identified, tagged, and/or segregated for repair or disposal in a manner that minimizes the risk of inadvertent use, improper use, or risk to the integrity of finished product. Records of the handling, corrective action, and/or disposal of non-conforming equipment shall be maintained.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

4.1.8 Grounds and Roadways

The areas around each of the facilities were observed clean and maintained in good condition. Grassy areas were manicured, rock barriers were provided along the base of each of the buildings; no harborage areas were observed. The entry, parking lots, and the loading dock areas were hard surfaced and/or concrete, in good condition, and free of harborage or storage. The surfaces were sloped to prevent ponding. Standing water was not observed. Sidewalks to the site were concrete.

- 4.1.8.1** A suitable external environment shall be established, and the effectiveness of the measures shall be monitored and periodically reviewed. The premises, its surrounding areas, storage facilities, machinery, and equipment shall be kept free of waste or accumulated debris and vegetation controlled so as not to attract pests and vermin or present a food safety hazard to the sanitary operation of the site.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.1.8.2** Paths, roadways, and loading and unloading areas shall be maintained so as not to present a hazard to the food safety operation of the premises. They shall be adequately drained to prevent pooling of water. Drains shall be separate from the site drainage system and regularly cleared of debris.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.1.8.3** Paths from amenities leading to site entrances shall be effectively sealed.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

4.2.1 Repairs and Maintenance

Maintenance was managed through a software program designed to manage maintenance activities. The software included the list of PMs that were due at any time. Work orders were provided with an expected due date and completed PM work orders regenerated themselves to the next due date based on the assigned frequency.

Maintenance was under the responsibility of the General Manager and maintenance completion/open activities were reviewed in weekly SQF meetings.

The process allowed anyone (supervisor or QA and above) to log in and request a work order.

The system in place for inspections on Priority 1 (food contact) after repair was to inspect the repair and record the inspection in the Quality Management Software.

Temporary repairs were allowed as long as they were logged into the maintenance repair log, they were not allowed to use unsafe materials (tape, wood, wire, cardboard, plastic), and they were fixed as soon as possible and tracked through the QA program.

Food grade and non-food grade lubricants were kept in separate cabinets and only food grade lubricants were used on production equipment. Product contact surfaces were not painted.

Minor 11.2.1.4: A requested repair on the squeeze pack line (maintenance work order 9258) stated the pump had to be disassembled and put back together correctly. The notification to the Production Supervisor and/or QA Supervisor was not recorded, and no Quality Management Inspection by QA had been completed during/after the repair, as required by the procedure.

- 4.2.1.1** The methods and responsibility for the maintenance and repair of plant, equipment, and buildings shall be documented, planned, and implemented in a manner that minimizes the risk of product, packaging, or equipment contamination.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.2.1.2** Routine maintenance of plant and equipment in any pet food processing, handling, or storage area shall be performed according to a maintenance control schedule and recorded.
The maintenance schedule shall be prepared to cover building, equipment, and other areas of the premises critical to the maintenance of product safety and quality.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.2.1.3** Failures of plant and equipment in any pet food processing, handling, or storage area shall be documented, reviewed and their repair incorporated into the maintenance control schedule.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.2.1.4** Site supervisors shall be notified when maintenance or repairs are to be undertaken in any processing, handling, or storage area.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.2.1.5** The maintenance supervisor and the site supervisor shall be informed if any repairs or maintenance activities pose a potential threat to product safety (i.e., pieces of electrical wire, damaged light fittings, and loose overhead fittings). When possible, maintenance is to be conducted outside operating times.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.2.1.6** Temporary repairs, where required, shall not pose a food safety risk and shall be included in the cleaning program. There shall be a plan in place to address temporary repairs to ensure they do not become permanent solutions.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.2.1.7** Pet food contact equipment and equipment located over pet food contact equipment shall be lubricated with food grade lubricants, and its use shall be controlled to minimize the contamination of the product.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.2.1.8** Paint used in a pet food handling or contact zone shall be suitable for use, in good condition, and not used on any product contact surface.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

4.2.2 Maintenance Staff and Contractors

Maintenance contractors were escorted by the maintenance staff. As part of signing in, the contractor had to acknowledge GMP and infectious disease conditions. Maintenance and contractors were required to remove tools and parts upon completion of work before sanitation would occur.

Any contractor maintenance activity in food contact areas would be cleaned as part of a wet clean (change-over) or would be required to be inspected by QA after completion of the repair.

4.2.2.1 Maintenance staff and contractors shall comply with the site's personnel and process hygiene requirements (refer to 4.3).

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

4.2.2.2 All maintenance and other engineering contractors required to work on-site shall be trained in the site's food safety and hygiene procedures or shall be escorted at all times until their work is completed.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

4.2.2.3 Maintenance staff and contractors shall remove all tools and debris from any maintenance activity once it has been completed and inform the area supervisor and maintenance supervisor so appropriate hygiene and sanitation can be completed and a pre-operational inspection conducted prior to restarting site operations.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

4.2.3 Calibration

Calibration was the responsibility of QA and maintenance. Calibration records included a Calibration Schedule. This schedule identified the instrument's model, location, plant ID, and test results. Calibration records on a new metal detector installation 1/30/2024, and calibration certificates for annual Metal Detector Calibrations 12/15/2023 (supplier specification calibration) were provided. Scales 6/23/2023 (no failures were recorded), and aflatoxin Testers 3/28/24.

RTD - Roasters - 4/12/2024 and Magnets - 4/2/2024 were included in the program.

Equipment was calibrated against supplier specifications and NIST; no regulatory requirements of calibration applied.

Calibration failures were addressed in the program. The procedure listed the site's responsibility to address product disposition by QA should equipment be found out of calibration. Equipment was protected from damage and from unauthorized adjustments.

4.2.3.1 The methods and responsibility for calibration and re-calibration of measuring, testing, and inspection equipment used for monitoring activities outlined in pre-requisite programs, food safety plans and other process controls, or to demonstrate compliance with customer specifications, shall be documented and implemented. Software used for such activities shall be validated as appropriate.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

4.2.3.2 Equipment shall be calibrated against national or international reference standards and methods or to an accuracy appropriate to its use. In cases where standards are not available, the site shall provide evidence to support the calibration reference method applied.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

4.2.3.3 Calibration shall be performed according to regulatory requirements and/or to the equipment manufacturer's recommended schedule.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.2.3.4** Procedures shall be documented and implemented to address the resolution of potentially affected products should measuring, testing, and inspection equipment be found to be out of calibration state.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.2.3.5** Calibrated measuring, testing, and inspection equipment shall be protected from damage and unauthorized adjustment.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.2.3.6** A directory of measuring, testing, and inspection equipment requiring calibration and records of calibration tests shall be maintained.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

4.2.4 Pest Prevention

Pest control was managed through a third party PCO - the contract was reviewed / signed annually (1/29/2024). Pest control at the three sites was managed under the same agreement and included weekly inspections, interior rodent traps, ILT checks, and pheromone checks. The plan included monthly exterior bait station treatments and as-needed exterior perimeter treatments. Documents reviewed in the Pest Logbook were the PCO Business License (8/31/2026), Certificate of Insurance (10/1/2024), Applicator License (4/21/2024), list of Authorized Products (1/29/2024), Pest Control Material Authorization for Organic Facilities (1/29/2024), and SDS for each approved chemical. The Device Map was reviewed annually (3/11/2024) and a Pest Sighting Log was maintained by the site.

Reviewed Pest Inspection Reports (printed hard copy) from 4/15/2024, 4/2/2025, 2/5/24, and 1/29/24 with the reports being signed by the SQF Practitioner. The report format included a Recommendations tracker - a recommendation on floor cracks were signed off by the PCO on 4/5/2024. The PCO provided a summary of each visit as the last decision in each report.

A PCO QA Audit was completed by the pest control management team on 3/18/2024. The audit included a site inspection and made no recommendations for changes. The Quarterly Pest Activity Trend Report was included at the back of the Logbook with trends within listed thresholds. The areas were observed clean and free of harborage during the audit.

The site maintained the list of observations on their QA software program and tracked them through to completion. Examples of Closed Cases were provided during the audit included sealing up cracks around inlet augers in the peanut facility. The site did not store pesticides.

Minor 11.2.4.2: A can of Raid was observed in a janitorial cabinet at the Perry warehouse.

- 4.2.4.1** A documented pest prevention program shall be effectively implemented. It shall:
- i. Describe the methods and responsibility for the development, implementation, and maintenance of the pest prevention program;
 - ii. Record pest sightings and trend the frequency of pest activity to target pesticide applications;
 - iii. Outline the methods used to prevent pest problems;
 - iv. Outline the pest elimination methods and the appropriate documentation for each inspection;
 - v. Outline the frequency with which pest status is to be checked;
 - vi. Include on a site map the identification, location, number, and type of applied pest control/monitoring devices;
 - vii. List the chemicals used. They are required to be approved by the relevant authority and their Safety Data Sheets (SDS) made available;
 - viii. Outline the methods used to make staff aware of the bait control program and the measures to take when they come into contact with a bait station;
 - ix. Outline the requirements for staff awareness and training in the use of pest and vermin control chemicals and baits; and
 - x. Measure the effectiveness of the program to verify the elimination of applicable pests and identify trends.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.2.4.2** Pest contractors and/or internal pest controllers shall:
- i. Be licensed and approved by the local relevant authority;
 - ii. Use only trained and qualified operators who comply with regulatory requirements;
 - iii. Use only approved chemicals;
 - iv. Provide a pest prevention plan (refer to 2.3.2.8) which includes a site map indicating the location of bait stations, traps, and other applicable pest control/monitoring devices;
 - v. Report to a responsible authorized person on entering the premises and after the completion of inspections or treatments;
 - vi. Provide regular inspections for pest activity with appropriate action taken if pests are present, and
 - vii. Provide a written report of their findings and the inspections and treatments applied.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.2.4.3** Identified pest activity shall not present a risk of contamination to pet food products, raw materials, or packaging.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.2.4.4** Pet food products, raw materials, or packaging that are found to be contaminated by pest activity shall be effectively disposed of and the source of pest infestation investigated and resolved. Records shall be kept of the disposal, investigation, and resolution.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.2.4.6** No animals shall be permitted on-site in pet food handling or storage areas.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

4.2.5 Cleaning and Sanitation

Master Cleaning records were maintained on Google Sheets for each of the three sites and handheld tablets were provided for employees to record the completed work. The cleaning schedule was broken down to the specific tasks required in each room. QA had responsibility for verifying completion and providing a % Completion Score in weekly SQF Meeting. Records were complete and completion rates for the past 6 months showed typical completion rates >80%, which was the stated objective. The score card was programed to report each area and coded for green cells to be in spec, yellow cells listed as a warning, and red cells listed as a failure. For food contact parts, COP tanks were used for cleaning. Cleaning records on COP included time, temp, and titration of the sanitizer being used. Records were captured in the electronic QA Software program. Titrations of the detergent and sanitizer were listed for each batch with a picture of the COP Chart taken when completed. Chemical training records were requested (jb, gg, bl) and reviewed. Each cleaning record was electronically verified by QA after completion.

No CIP was used.

Cleaning equipment was stored on designated racks and hooks. Equipment was observed to be clean and free of damage.

Each plant used a "Drying room". Cleaned equipment was stored clean and on racks in these heated rooms to drive out any residual water in the equipment prior to use. Dryer rooms were maintained >95F.

Pre-Op inspections were tracked on an excel log and data was embedded in the ATP reader. QA conducted the visual inspections and conducted ATP checks after each cleaning (monthly shutdown). Reviewed the inspections/pre-op for the last two inspections 4/3/2024 through 4/8/2024 that were conducted after the monthly deep clean - each of the checks were in limit. Randomly reviewed completed pre-ops for the past 6 months and excel logs appeared up to date.

Janitorial cleaning (break rooms, toilet rooms, locker rooms) was cleaned by a contracted cleaning service. Completed MCS were posted/completed by the service provider.

- 4.2.5.1** The methods and responsibility for the effective cleaning of the pet food handling and processing equipment, environment, and storage areas shall be documented and implemented. Consideration shall be given to:
- i. What is to be cleaned;
 - ii. How it is to be cleaned;
 - iii. When it is to be cleaned;
 - iv. Who is responsible for the cleaning;
 - v. Validation of cleaning procedures for pet food contact surfaces (including CIP);
 - vi. Methods used to confirm the correct concentrations of detergents and sanitizers; and
 - vii. The responsibility and methods used to verify the effectiveness of the cleaning and sanitation program.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.2.5.2** Detergents and sanitizers shall be suitable for use in a pet food manufacturing environment, labeled according to regulatory requirements, and purchased in accordance with applicable legislation. The organization shall ensure that detergents and sanitizers are stored as outlined in element 4.6.4 and are handled only by trained staff.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

4.2.5.3 Detergents and sanitizers that have been mixed for use shall be correctly mixed according to manufacturers' instructions, stored in containers that are suitable for use, and clearly identified. Mix concentrations shall be verified and records maintained.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

4.2.5.5 Cleaning equipment, tools, racks, and other items used in support of the cleaning and sanitizing program shall be clearly identified, stored, and maintained in a manner that prevents contamination of processing, product handling equipment, and storage areas as well as the tools themselves.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

4.2.5.6 Suitably equipped areas shall be designated for cleaning product containers, knives, cutting boards, and other utensils used by staff. These cleaning operations shall be controlled so as not to interfere with manufacturing operations, equipment, or product. Racks and containers for storing cleaned utensils shall be provided as required.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

4.2.5.7 Pre-operational inspections shall be conducted following cleaning and sanitation operations to ensure pet food processing areas, product contact surfaces, equipment, staff amenities, sanitary facilities, and other essential areas are clean before the commencement of production. Pre-operational inspections shall be conducted by qualified personnel.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

4.2.5.8 Staff amenities, sanitary facilities, and other essential areas shall be inspected by qualified personnel at a defined frequency to ensure the areas are clean.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

4.2.5.9 The responsibility and methods used to verify the effectiveness of the cleaning procedures shall be documented and implemented. A verification schedule shall be prepared.
A record of pre-operational hygiene inspections, cleaning and sanitation activities, and verification activities shall be maintained.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

4.3.1 Personnel Welfare

The policy Illness Reporting (4/12/23) was in place and trained contractors, visitors, and employees (at hire and annually). The policy included annual sign-off, monitoring of employee health through supervisor observations (daily), and though daily QA Line Audits. Inspections included employee practices such as handwashing, proper wearing of hairnets and proper uniforms, and ensuring employees did not appear ill. The GMP policy that was used for employee training and for GMP inspections called out employee health as a concern that had to be reported to HR.

The employee GMP required the use of metal detector bandages (bandages were tested monthly in a metal detector). In open food areas, employees were required to wear uniforms and supervisors/managers wore smocks; food handler gloves were used when handling products or product-contact areas. Bodily fluid spill kits were provided with emergency supply cabinets located in the facility.

- 4.3.1.1** Personnel who are known to be carriers of infectious diseases that present a health risk to others through the packing or storage processes shall not engage in the processing or packing of pet food or enter storage areas where pet food is exposed.

Code Amendment #1

A medical screening procedure shall be in place for all employees, visitors and contractors who handle exposed product or food contact surfaces.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.3.1.2** The site shall have measures in place to prevent contact of materials, ingredients, pet food packaging, pet food, or pet food contact surfaces from any bodily fluids from open wounds, coughing, sneezing, spitting, or any other means.
- In the event of an injury that causes spillage of bodily fluid, a properly trained staff member shall ensure that all affected areas including handling and processing areas have been adequately cleaned and that all materials and products have been quarantined and/or disposed of.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.3.1.3** Personnel with exposed cuts, sores, or lesions shall not engage in handling or processing products or handling primary packaging or pet food contact surfaces. Minor cuts or abrasions on exposed parts of the body shall be covered with a colored bandage containing a metal strip or an alternative suitable waterproof and colored dressing.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

4.3.2 Handwashing

The enforced hand washing policy required any employee or visitor to wash hands prior to entry to any processing or packaging rooms. Hand wash basins were provided. Boots were taken captive to the processing/packaging room and visitors were required to wear booties provided by management.

Hand wash sinks were located just outside each production/packaging room and were constructed of stainless steel, had hands-free water, hands-free liquid soap and towels. Hand sanitizer stations were positioned at each process entry for sanitizing hands. Hand wash reminder signs were posted at the exit of each toilet room, at the exit of the locker area, at the exit of the break rooms, and at the entrance to the site. Employees were observed washing their hands and using proper gowning procedures (boots, hairnets, handwashing, smocks, and gloving) during the audit.

- 4.3.2.1** All personnel shall have clean hands and hands shall be washed by all staff, contractors, and visitors:
- i. On entering pet food handling or processing areas;
 - ii. After each visit to a toilet;
 - iii. After using a handkerchief;
 - iv. After smoking, eating, or drinking; and
 - v. After handling wash down hoses, cleaning materials, dropped product, or contaminated material.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.3.2.2** Handwash stations shall be provided adjacent to all personnel access points and in accessible locations throughout pet food handling and processing areas as required.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.3.2.3** Handwash stations shall be constructed of stainless steel or similar non-corrosive material and at a minimum supplied with:
- i. A potable water supply at an appropriate temperature;
 - ii. Liquid soap contained within a fixed dispenser;
 - iii. Paper towels in a hands-free cleanable dispenser; and
 - iv. A means of containing used paper towels.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.3.2.4** The following additional facilities shall be provided in high-risk areas:
- i. Hands-free operated taps; and
 - ii. Hand sanitizers.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.3.2.5** Signage in appropriate languages instructing people to wash their hands before entering the pet food processing areas shall be provided in a prominent position in break rooms, at break rooms exits, toilet rooms, and in outside eating areas as applicable.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.3.2.6** When gloves are used, personnel shall maintain the handwashing practices outlined above.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

4.3.3 Clothing and Personal Effects

A risk analysis of PPE and clothing requirements was completed and provided by QA. Laundered uniform and hair restraint requirements were in place to protect materials, food, and food contact surfaces from unintentional microbiological or allergen cross-contamination. Personnel were required to wear a company provided uniform (shirt & pants) and managers/ supervisors wore a smock outer garment over appropriate street clothing in any production or storage areas of the Main and Peanut Facilities. Uniforms and smocks were laundered by an approved service supplier and stored on racks located in the locker rooms. Shoes were captive to the production facilities and visitors were required to wear disposable smocks and booties while in the plant. Excessively soiled uniforms could be changed or replaced, when necessary. Disposable smocks, different color hairnet, and booties were provided for non-raw-process employees and visitors entering the raw side of the plant. An ante room was used between the two sides for changing uniforms. Hooks were located nearby or adjacent to the personnel access doorways and handwashing facilities for the temporary storage of protective clothing when personnel left processing areas. Employees handling food or food contact were required to wear single use, disposable gloves. Jewelry, with the exception of plain bands with no stones, prescribed medical alert jewelry, and other loose objects were not permitted to be worn or taken into a food handling or processing operation or into any area where food is exposed.

- 4.3.3.1** The site shall undertake a risk analysis to ensure that the clothing and hair policy protects materials, pet food, and pet food contact surfaces from unintentional microbiological or physical contamination.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.3.3.2** Clothing worn by staff engaged in handling pet food shall be maintained, stored, laundered, and worn so as not to present a contamination risk to products.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.3.3.3** Clothing, including shoes, shall be clean at the commencement of each shift and maintained in a serviceable condition.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.3.3.4** Excessively soiled uniforms shall be changed or replaced where they present a product contamination risk.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.3.3.5** Disposable gloves and aprons shall be changed after each break, upon re-entry into the processing area, and when damaged. Non-disposable aprons and gloves shall be cleaned and sanitized as required and when not in use stored on racks provided in the processing area or designated sealed containers in personnel lockers and not on packaging, ingredients, product, or equipment.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.3.3.6** Protective clothing shall be manufactured from material that will not contaminate pet food and is easily cleaned. All protective clothing shall be cleaned after use or at a frequency to control contamination and stored in a clean and serviceable condition to prevent microbiological or cross-contact allergen contamination.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.3.3.7** Racks shall be provided for the temporary storage of protective clothing when staff leave the processing area and shall be provided nearby or adjacent to the personnel access doorways and handwashing facilities.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.3.3.8** Jewelry and other loose objects shall not be worn or taken into a pet food handling or processing operation or any area where pet food is exposed. The wearing of plain bands with no stones, prescribed medical alert bracelets, or jewelry accepted for religious or cultural reasons can be permitted, provided they are properly covered and do not pose a food safety risk.
All exceptions shall meet regulatory and customer requirements and shall be subject to a risk assessment and evidence of ongoing risk management.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

4.3.4 Visitors

Visitors and management staff were required to comply with the requirements of the site's GMP policy. This policy included the wearing of appropriate smocks/hairnets, acknowledgement of not having communicable food-borne disease or illness, entering and exiting food handling areas through designated entrance points, and to comply with the hand washing and personnel practice requirements. Visitors were required to wear disposable smocks and booties and were escorted while in any food processing, handling and storage areas.

- 4.3.4.1** All visitors shall be trained in the site's food safety and hygiene procedures before entering any pet food processing or handling areas or shall be escorted at all times in pet food processing, handling, and storage areas.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.3.4.2** All visitors, including management staff, shall be required to remove jewelry and other loose objects in accordance with the facilities Good Manufacturing Practices and 4.3.3.8. All visitors shall wear suitable clothing and footwear when entering any pet food processing or handling area.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

4.3.4.3 Visitors exhibiting visible signs of illness shall be prevented from entering areas in which pet food is handled or processed.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

4.3.4.4 Visitors shall enter and exit pet food handling areas through the proper staff entrance points and comply with all handwashing and personnel practice requirements.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

4.3.5 Staff Amenities (change rooms, toilets, break rooms)

Staff amenities included a raw side break room (peanut facility), RTE side breakroom, locker areas, toilet rooms, and offices. Amenity areas were well lit, clean, and in good condition. RTE rooms (majority of processing in the peanut and main facilities) maintained separation from raw peanut storage or processing. Employees were provided with personal lockers to store their outdoor clothing and personal items. Showers were provided, but not required. Toilet rooms were adequately designed and built for the number of employees; they were observed clean and properly maintained.

Hand wash basins supplied with warm potable water, liquid soap, paper towels and sanitizer. Hand wash reminder signs were posted in the break rooms, toilet rooms, at each hand sink, and at the entrance area. Sanitary drainage was separate from any process drains and was connected directly to municipal sewerage system. The lunch/break rooms were segregated from the food processing, handling and storage areas. Lunchrooms were sufficient in size for the number of employees working at each facility. Lunchrooms included hot/cold potable water, refrigerators, microwave ovens, and were observed cleaned and maintained. Small outside eating and smoking areas were kept clean and free from waste.

4.3.5.1 Staff amenities shall have documented cleaning procedures, be supplied with appropriate lighting and ventilation, and shall be made available for the use of all persons engaged in the handling and processing of product.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

4.3.5.2 Change rooms shall be provided to enable staff and visitors to change into and out of protective clothing as required. Change rooms shall be kept clean.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

4.3.5.3 High-risk change areas shall be provided for staff engaged in the processing of high-risk pet foods or processing operations in which clothing can be soiled.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

4.3.5.4 Provision shall be made for staff to store their street clothing and personal items separate from clean uniforms, pet food contact zones, and pet food and packaging storage areas.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

4.3.5.5 Where required, a sufficient number of showers shall be provided for use by staff.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

4.3.5.6 Toilet rooms shall be:

- i. Designed and constructed so that they are accessible to staff and separate from any processing and pet food handling operations;
- ii. Accessed from the processing area via an airlock vented to the exterior or through an adjoining room;
- iii. Sufficient in number for the maximum number of staff;
- iv. Constructed so that they can be easily cleaned and maintained;
- v. Include an area inside or nearby for storing protective clothing, outer garments, and other items while using the facilities; and
- vi. Kept clean and tidy.

Tools/equipment used for cleaning toilet rooms shall not be used to clean processing areas.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

4.3.5.7 Sanitary drainage shall not be connected to any other drains within the premises and shall be directed to a septic tank or a sewerage system in accordance with regulations.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

4.3.5.8 Handwashing basins shall be provided immediately outside or inside the toilet room and designed as outlined in 4.3.2.3.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

4.3.5.9 Separate break rooms shall be provided away from pet food contact/handling zone. Break rooms shall be:

- i. Ventilated and well lit;
- ii. Provided with adequate tables and seating to cater for the maximum number of staff at one sitting;
- iii. Equipped with a sink serviced with hot and cold potable water for washing utensils;
- iv. Equipped with refrigeration and heating facilities enabling them to store or heat food and to prepare non-alcoholic beverages if required; and
- v. Kept clean and free from waste materials and pests.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

4.3.5.10 Where outside eating areas are provided, they should be kept clean and free from waste materials and maintained in a manner that minimizes the potential for introduction of contamination, including pests to the site.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

4.4.1 Staff Engaged in Food Handling and Processing Operations

Workers were required to wear hairnets and beard nets (if applicable) when entering food processing or handling areas. Smoking, chewing, eating, or spitting was not permitted in process or storage area. Employees were observed complying with these restrictions during the audit. Smoking, including the use of e-cigarettes, was restricted to designated outside smoking areas. Drinking water coolers and the use of company issued drinking water containers was permitted in the food processing, handling or storage areas of the facility. The flow of personnel-maintained separation from raw/RTE and addressed allergen cross-contamination in a manner that minimized product risk.

Sensory evaluations were conducted in hallway areas and away from open products. Inspection desks were located next to handwashing sinks. Packaging leads and operators were trained in sensory testing and hygiene requirements. Sampling procedures were posted and included taking samples off the line, products were tasted using sterile tongue depressors, used tongue depressor were disposed of in the trash receptacle, and employees were required to wash and sanitize their hands prior to returning to the production line.

4.4.1.1 All personnel engaged in any pet food handling, preparation, or processing operations shall ensure that products and materials are handled and stored in such a way as to prevent damage or product contamination. They shall comply with the following processing practices:

- i. Personnel entry to processing areas shall be through the personnel access doors only;
- ii. All doors shall be kept closed. Doors shall not be open for extended periods when access is required for waste removal or receiving of product/ingredient/packaging;
- iii. Packaging, product, and ingredients shall be kept in appropriate containers as required and off the floor;
- iv. Waste shall be contained in the bins identified for this purpose and removed from the processing area on a regular basis and not left to accumulate; and
- v. All wash down and compressed air hoses shall be stored on hose racks after use and not left on the floor.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

4.4.1.2 Personnel working in or visiting pet food handling or processing operations shall ensure that:

- i. Staff shall not eat or taste any product being processed in the pet food handling/contact zone, except as noted in element 4.4.1.4;
- ii. The wearing of false fingernails, false eyelashes, eyelash extensions, long nails, or fingernail polish is not permitted when handling exposed pet food;
- iii. Hair restraints, and beard covers, where applicable, shall be used in areas where product is exposed.
- iv. Smoking, chewing, eating, or spitting is not permitted in areas where product is produced, stored, or otherwise exposed.
- v. Drinking of water is permissible only under conditions that prevent contamination or other food safety risks from occurring. Drinking water containers in production and storage areas shall be stored in clear, covered containers and in designated areas away from raw materials, packaging, tools, or equipment storage.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

4.4.1.3 The flow of personnel in pet food processing and handling areas shall be managed such that the potential for contamination is minimized.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.4.1.4** In circumstances where it is necessary to undertake sensory evaluations in a pet food handling/contact zone the site shall implement controls and procedures to ensure:
- i. Pet food safety is not compromised;
 - ii. Sensory evaluations are conducted by authorized personnel only;
 - iii. A high standard of personal hygiene is practiced by personnel conducting sensory evaluations;
 - iv. Sensory evaluations are conducted in areas equipped for the purpose; and
 - v. Equipment used for sensory evaluations is sanitized, maintained, and stored separate from processing equipment.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

4.5.1 Water Supply

The water was from the local municipality. The city provided the site monthly reports on testing results (reviewed reports for 2023-2024 from samples taken at different areas throughout the city). The city water report included microbiological analysis and heavy metal and chemical analysis results. Hot water was supplied from a large water heater (the site did not use a commercial boiler). The temperature of water for each COP wash provided evidence of adequate supply of hot water. Backflow prevention testing (12/19/2023) were provided for the Peanut Facility and the Main Facility- results were listed as Pass. Non-potable water was not utilized. Water was not stored.

- 4.5.1.1** Adequate supplies of potable water drawn from a known clean source shall be provided for use during processing operations, as an ingredient, and for cleaning the premises and equipment. The source of potable water shall be identified as well as on-site storage (if applicable) and reticulation within the facility.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.5.1.2** Contingency plans shall be in place for instances when the potable water supply is deemed to be contaminated or otherwise inappropriate for use.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.5.1.3** Supplies of hot and cold water shall be provided as required to enable the effective cleaning of the premises and equipment.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.5.1.4** The delivery of water within the premises shall ensure potable water is not contaminated. Testing of the backflow system, where possible, shall be conducted at least annually and records shall be maintained.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.5.1.5** The use of non-potable water shall be controlled such that:
- i. There is no cross-contamination between potable and non-potable water lines;
 - ii. Non-potable water piping and outlets are clearly identified; and
 - iii. Hoses, taps, and other similar sources of possible contamination are designed to prevent back flow or back siphonage.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE: Non-potable water was not utilized.

- 4.5.1.6** Where water is stored on-site, storage facilities shall be adequately designed, constructed, and routinely cleaned to prevent contamination.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE: Water was not stored.

4.5.2 Water Treatment

Water was not treated.

4.5.3 Water Quality

Water was used for monthly deep cleaning activities and for amenities. Water was not part of any processing. The city provided monthly water testing reports for different sites that were tested around the municipality each month.

In addition to the city testing, the site conducted annual testing of water to include chlorine, copper, lead, coliform, and E. coli using a 17025 Laboratory. The last test was completed 1/15/2024 for each site. Results were available for review.

- 4.5.3.1** Water shall comply with local, national, or internationally recognized potable water microbiological and quality standards as required when used for:
- i. Washing, thawing, and treating pet food;
 - ii. Handwashing
 - iii. To convey pet food;
 - iv. As an ingredient or pet food processing aid;
 - v. Cleaning pet food contact surfaces and equipment;
 - vi. The manufacture of ice; or
 - vii. The manufacture of steam that will come into contact with pet food or used to heat water that will come in contact with pet food.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.5.3.2** Microbiological analysis of the water and ice supply shall be conducted to verify the cleanliness of the supply, the monitoring activities, and the effectiveness of the treatment measures implemented. Samples for analysis shall be taken at sources supplying water for the process or cleaning, or from within the site. The frequency of analysis shall be risk-based and at a minimum annually.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.5.3.3** Water and ice shall be analyzed using reference standards and methods.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

4.5.4 Ice Supply

Ice was not used.

4.5.5 Air and Other Gasses

Compressed air was used for cleaning jars prior to filling.

Compressed air was sampled/tested annually through an air sampler system. The last check on compressed air was completed 12/6/2023 for Yeast and Mold, results were between ND and 8 for each of the 8 completed checks. Compressed gas was not used in packaging.

- 4.5.5.1** Compressed air or other gases (e.g., nitrogen, carbon dioxide) that contact pet food or pet food contact surfaces shall be clean and present no risk to food safety.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.5.5.2** Compressed air systems, and systems used to store or dispense other gases that come into contact with pet food or pet food contact surfaces shall be maintained and regularly monitored for quality and applicable food safety hazards. The frequency of analysis shall be risk-based and at a minimum annually.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

4.6.1 Receipt, Storage and Handling of Goods

Materials were stored in totes and Kraft bags on pallets and were kept off the floors and in safe and hygienic condition. Raw peanuts were cleaned, roasted, and stored in stainless steel silos prior to processing. Equipment was stored clean and covered when not in use. Chemicals were stored in secured cabinets. Dock doors were cushioned and protected products while loading/unloading. Cooler condensers were drained and kept free from dripping. Ingredients, raw materials, processing aids, and packaging were observed properly stored to minimize cross contamination risks.

Unprocessed raw materials were received and stored separately from processed raw materials to avoid cross-contamination risk. A new computerized inventory management system (ERP) was utilized to ensure effective FIFO rotation. No expired raw materials, ingredients, packaging materials or finished products were observed in the storage or production areas during the duration of the audit. Raw materials, ingredients, packaging, equipment, chemicals, or finished products were not held under temporary or overflow conditions.

- 4.6.1.1** The site shall document and implement an effective storage plan that allows for the safe, hygienic receipt and storage of raw materials (i.e., frozen, chilled, and ambient), ingredients, packaging, equipment, and chemicals.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.6.1.2** Controls shall be in place to ensure all ingredients, raw materials, processing aids, and packaging are received and stored properly to prevent cross-contamination risks. Unprocessed raw materials shall be received and stored separately from processed raw materials to avoid cross-contamination risk.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.6.1.3** The responsibility and methods for ensuring effective stock rotation principles are applied shall be documented and implemented.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.6.1.4** Procedures shall be in place to ensure that all ingredients, materials, work-in-progress, rework, and finished product are utilized within their designated shelf life.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

4.6.2 Cold Storage, Freezing, and Chilling of Pet Food

The Main Facility and the warehouse each maintained a small cooler. Coolers were in place for quality and shelf life for pasteurized tree nuts. Forms were provided electronically by QA on the electronic software, checks were conducted daily for temperature and humidity and QA would be provided an automatic email alert if results were out of the allowed limits. The coolers were clean and in good condition during the audit.

- 4.6.2.1** The site shall provide confirmation of the effective operational performance of freezing, chilling, and cold storage facilities. Chillers, blast freezers, and cold storage rooms shall be designed and constructed to allow for the hygienic and efficient refrigeration of pet food and easily accessible for inspection and cleaning.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.6.2.2** Sufficient refrigeration capacity shall be available to chill, freeze, store chilled, or store frozen the maximum anticipated throughput of product with allowance for periodic cleaning of refrigerated areas.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.6.2.3** The site shall have a written procedure for monitoring temperatures, including the frequency of checks, and corrective actions if the temperature is out of specification
Freezing, chilling, and cold storage rooms shall be fitted with temperature monitoring equipment that is located to monitor the warmest part of the room and be fitted with a temperature measurement device that is easily readable and accessible. Records shall be kept of frozen, cold, and chilled storage room temperatures.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.6.2.4** Discharge from defrost and condensate lines shall be controlled and discharged to the drainage system.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

4.6.3 Storage of Dry Ingredients, Packaging, and Shelf Stable Packaged Goods

Storage areas for ingredients, packaging, and other dry goods were located away from wet areas. Warehouse racks were constructed to protect the materials from contamination and deterioration. Storage areas were clean and maintained to prevent harborage. Master Cleaning Schedules and Inspections included floor areas and behind racking. Storage area cleaning requirements were detailed in the completed master cleaning schedules (Google Sheets) provided during the audit. These areas were clean and organized during the audit.

- 4.6.3.1** Rooms used for the storage of product ingredients, packaging, and other dry goods shall be located away from wet areas and constructed to protect the product from contamination and deterioration and to prevent packaging from becoming a harborage for pests or vermin.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.6.3.2** Racks provided for the storage of packaging shall be constructed of impervious materials and designed to enable cleaning and inspection of the floors and behind the racks. Storage areas shall be cleaned at a predetermined frequency.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

4.6.4 Storage of Hazardous Chemicals and Toxic Substances

Chemicals were observed clearly labeled. Sanitizers were diluted for use and provided for line operators. The sanitation chemical register was used to track chemical usage. SDS logbooks were maintained by QA and were made available to employees. Maintenance shops kept food and non-food chemicals stored in separate labeled cabinets. Sanitation chemicals were kept in locked supply rooms next to the sanitation rooms. Processing utensils and packaging materials were not stored in areas used to store chemicals. Chemicals were labeled for use in food processing facilities. Daily supplies of chemicals (alcohol sanitizer) were appropriately labeled and stored. Personnel were trained in handling chemicals as part of annual training requirements. Spill kits, first aid equipment and personnel protective equipment (PPE) were provided in storage areas. Empty containers were triple rinsed, segregated and stored for pick-up.

- 4.6.4.1** Hazardous chemicals and toxic substances with the potential for pet food contamination shall be:
- i. Clearly labelled, identifying and matching the contents of their containers;
 - ii. Included in a current register of all hazardous chemicals and toxic substances that are stored on-site; and
 - iii. Supplemented with current Safety Data Sheets (SDS) made available to all staff.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.6.4.2** Storage of hazardous chemicals and toxic substances shall be:
- i. An area with appropriate signage indicating that the area is for hazardous storage;
 - ii. Controlled, lockable, and accessible only by personnel trained in the storage and use of chemicals;
 - iii. Adequately ventilated;
 - iv. Stored where intended and not comingled (e.g., food versus non-food grade);
 - v. Designed such that pesticides, rodenticides, fumigants, and insecticides are stored separate from sanitizers and detergents; and
 - vi. In a manner that prevents a hazard to finished product or product contact surfaces.
- Processing utensils and packaging shall not be stored in areas used to store hazardous chemicals and toxic substances.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.6.4.3** Hazardous chemicals and toxic substances shall be correctly labeled and:
- i. Used only according to manufacturer's instructions;
 - ii. Controlled to prevent contamination or a hazard to raw and packaging material, work-in-progress, finished product, or product contact surfaces;
 - iii. Returned to the appropriate storage areas after use, and
 - iv. Be compliant with national and local legislation.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.6.4.4** Daily supplies of chemicals used for continuous sanitizing of water or as a processing aid, or for emergency cleaning of pet food processing equipment or surfaces in pet food contact zones, may be stored within or in close proximity to a processing area, provided that access to the chemical storage facility is restricted to authorized personnel.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.6.4.5** Personnel who handle hazardous chemicals and toxic substances, including pesticides and cleaning chemicals:
- i. Shall be fully trained in their purpose, storage, handling, and use;
 - ii. Be provided with first aid equipment and personnel protective equipment; and
 - iii. Ensure compliance with the proper identification, storage, usage, disposal, and clean-up requirements.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.6.4.6** The site shall dispose of empty, obsolete and unused chemicals, pesticides, toxic substances, and containers in accordance with requirements and ensure that primary containers are:
- i. Not reused;
 - ii. Segregated and securely stored prior to collection; and
 - iii. Disposed through an approved vendor.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.6.4.7** In the event of a hazardous spill, the site shall:
- i. Have spillage clean-up instructions to ensure that the spill is properly contained; and
 - ii. Be equipped with spillage kits and cleaning equipment

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

4.6.5 Loading, Transport, and Unloading Practices

Written procedures (QMS-PRC0035, QMS-PRC0037) detailed the requirements of how each processing site used the offsite warehouse for ingredients and finished products. The site maintained a tractor and several trailers that were used to shuttle between processing facilities and the warehouse. The warehouse used doors on opposite sides of the building for shuttle trailers on one side and outbound finished product orders on the other. The trailers used for transporting between the sites were maintained per the Drop Trailer Cleaning & Inspection Log inspected prior to loading to ensure they were clean, in good repair, suitable for the purpose, and free from odors or other conditions. The Inbound Clean Truck Affidavit was used to document the inspection of the trailers used to transport products between the manufacturing facilities and the off-site warehouse. The Outbound Clean Truck Affidavit was used to document the inspection of the vehicles used to deliver finished goods to the customer.

Transport vehicles were required to be secured while in transit; inbound and outbound vehicles were secured with a traceable seal and transfer vehicles were locked. The loading docks were designed (dock cushions, overhangs, built-in dock plates) to minimize risk to materials when loading/unloading.

Ingredients, packaging, and products were at ambient temperature and did not require refrigerated or frozen conditions.

- 4.6.5.1** The practices applied during loading, transport, and unloading of pet food shall be documented, implemented, and designed to maintain appropriate storage conditions and product integrity. Pet food shall be loaded, transported, and unloaded under conditions suitable to prevent cross-contamination.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.6.5.2** Vehicles (e.g., trucks, vans, containers) used for transporting pet food within the site and from the site shall be inspected prior to loading to ensure they are clean, in good repair, suitable for the purpose, and free from odors or other conditions that may impact negatively on the product.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.6.5.3** Vehicles (e.g., trucks, vans, containers) shall be secured from tampering, using a seal or other agreed-upon and acceptable device or system.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.6.5.4** Loading and unloading docks shall be designed to protect the product during loading and unloading. Loading practices shall be designed to minimize unnecessary exposure of the product to conditions detrimental to maintaining the product and package integrity during loading and transport.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.6.5.5** Refrigerated units shall maintain the product at the required temperature and the unit's temperature settings shall be set, checked, and recorded before loading, and the product temperature shall be recorded at regular intervals during loading as appropriate.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.6.5.6** The refrigeration unit shall be operational at all times and checks completed of the unit's operation, the door seals, and the storage temperature at regular intervals during transit.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.6.5.7** On arrival, prior to opening the doors, the pet food transport vehicle's refrigeration unit's storage temperature settings and operating temperature shall be checked and recorded. Unloading shall be completed efficiently, and product temperatures shall be recorded at the commencement of unloading and at regular intervals during unloading.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.6.5.8** Unloading practices shall be designed to minimize unnecessary exposure of the product to conditions detrimental to maintaining the product and package integrity.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

4.7.1 High-Risk Processes

The products were RTE nut products with a water activity <0.65. Risks were divided and maintained separation from raw peanuts. Tree nuts were pasteurized or irradiated prior to accepting. Ambient air was tested for APC annually at each plant. The last tests were completed 1/10/2024 and 1/12/2024 with results through the air tester (1000L) each less than 5 cfu/m2. Workers on the raw side had special colored hair nets and smocks that were not allowed in other areas of the facility. An ante room was used between the RTE and raw peanut areas. Transfer points on products were roasters. These were designed to receive the raw peanuts on one side and unload the cooled/heat-treated product on the other.

- 4.7.1.1** The processing of high-risk pet food shall be conducted under controlled conditions such that sensitive areas in which high-risk pet food has undergone a "kill" step, a "food safety intervention," or is subject to post- process handling, are protected/segregated from other processes, raw materials, or staff who handle raw materials to ensure cross-contamination is minimized.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.7.1.2** Ambient air in high-risk areas shall be tested at least annually to confirm that it does not pose a risk to pet food safety.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

4.7.1.3 Areas in which high-risk processes are conducted shall only be serviced by staff dedicated to that function.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

4.7.1.4 Staff engaged in high-risk areas shall change into clean clothing and footwear or temporary protective outerwear when entering high-risk areas. Staff access points shall be located, designed, and equipped to enable staff to don distinctive protective clothing and to practice a high standard of personal hygiene to prevent product contamination.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

4.7.1.5 Product transfer points shall be located and designed so as not to compromise high-risk segregation and to minimize the risk of cross-contamination.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

4.7.2 Thawing of Food

The food was not thawed.

4.7.3 Control of Foreign Matter Contamination

Operations had responsibility for preventing foreign material contamination, including equipment inspections, magnet inspections, and metal detector checks.

Other than finished product jars, glassware and ceramics were not allowed in production rooms.

The Glass Brittle Plastic policy had been last reviewed on 4/14/2024. The policy required an annual audit on total units and facilities. High risk areas (within the filling cabinets) required inspection as part of the shift pre-ops (listed on electronic inspection forms).

The Policy included a Glass/Brittle Plastic Clean-Up procedure under the responsibility of Operations. 28 breakages have occurred in the past year (due to the process of packaging the majority of products were in glass jars). Records were captured electronically in the QA software and included detailed clean-up steps. These forms were required to be verified by a Level 3 Supervisor of QA to close out after the inspections had been completed. The Annual Audits were conducted room by room and were detailed to the lighting, wall units, mezzanine, silos, and control buttons on each equipment. Inspections reviewed included the Almond Room (12/20/2023), Cashew Room (12/18/2023) and Peanut Processing Room (1/31/2023).

No true glass was used on processing equipment.

Wood pallets were inspected prior to being brought into packaging areas. Pallets observed during the audit were clean and in good condition.

Knives were issued and inspected by QA (software).

Gaskets and other wear items (pumps) were included in the PM program and verified during the audit.

4.7.3.1 The responsibility and methods used to prevent foreign matter contamination of the product shall be documented, implemented, and communicated to all staff.

Inspections shall be performed (refer to 2.5.4.3) to ensure plant and equipment remain in good condition, equipment has not become detached or deteriorated, and is free from potential contaminants.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.7.3.2** Containers, equipment, and other utensils made of glass, porcelain, ceramics, laboratory glassware, or other like material (except where the product is contained in packaging made from these materials, or measurement instruments with glass dial covers or MIG thermometers required under regulation) shall not be permitted in pet food processing /contact zones.
- Where glass objects or similar material are required in pet food handling/contact zones, they shall be listed in a glass inventory, including details of their location and condition.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.7.3.3** Regular inspections of pet food handling/contact zones shall be conducted (refer to 2.5.4.3) to ensure they are free of glass or other like material and to establish changes to the condition of the objects listed in the glass inventory.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.7.3.4** Glass instrument dial covers on processing equipment and MIG thermometers shall be inspected at the start of each shift to confirm they have not been damaged.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.7.3.5** In circumstances where glass or similar material breakage occurs, the affected area shall be isolated, cleaned, thoroughly inspected (including cleaning equipment and footwear), and cleared by a suitably responsible person prior to the start of operations.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.7.3.6** Wooden pallets and other wooden utensils used in pet food processing and handling areas shall be dedicated for that purpose, clean, and maintained in good order. Their condition shall be subject to regular inspection.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.7.3.7** Loose metal objects on equipment, equipment covers, and overhead structures shall be removed or tightly fixed so as not to present a hazard.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.7.3.8** Knives and cutting instruments used in processing and packaging operations shall be controlled and kept clean and well maintained. Snap-off blades shall not be used in pet food manufacturing or storage areas.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.7.3.9** Gaskets, rubber impellers, and other equipment made of materials that can wear or deteriorate over time shall be inspected on a regular frequency (refer to 2.5.4.3).

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

4.7.4 Detection of Foreign Objects

Magnets were inspected daily by operators and recorded in the QA software system and a review of completed magnet checks for the last three months was completed during the audit. The log highlighted in red any abnormal findings with no abnormal findings being recorded (abnormal findings provided an auto-alert to QA management). The checks were conducted at the same time as sifter screen checks. A sifter check from 4/4/2024 showed very fine plastic shavings that were captured, but QA provided evidence the CAPA had been investigated and resolved.

Metal detectors were checked by packaging operators every two hours. Most metal detectors were flow through detectors prior to packaging. One case metal detector was used for non-butter type products (boxed peanuts, boxed tree nuts). QA conducted line checks in each production room each day. The purpose of these checks was to make sure the CCP/Preventive Control checks were effective and that paperwork to that time was being completed, as required.

Potential foreign materials required products to be placed on Hold for QA disposition.

- 4.7.4.1** The responsibility, methods, and frequency for monitoring, maintaining, calibrating, and using screens, sieves, filters, or other technologies to remove or detect foreign matter shall be documented and implemented.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.7.4.2** Where detection and/or removal systems are used, the site shall establish limits for detection based on a risk assessment of the product and its packaging and the location of the detector in the process.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.7.4.3** Metal detectors or other physical contaminant detection technologies shall be routinely monitored, validated, and verified for operational effectiveness. The equipment shall be designed to isolate defective product and indicate when it is rejected.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.7.4.4** Records shall be maintained of the inspection of foreign object detection devices, of any products rejected or removed by them, and of corrective and preventative actions resulting from the inspections.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.7.4.5** In all cases of foreign matter contamination, the affected batch or item shall be isolated, inspected, reworked, or disposed of. Records shall be maintained of the disposition.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

4.8.1 Waste Disposal

QMS-PLC0036 described the procedures the site used to manage their processing waste. A licensed contractor conducted twice-weekly pick-up from outside closed-top dumpsters to prevent excessive accumulation. Waste disposal areas were located in secured areas of the facility. The waste bins and equipment were maintained clean and in serviceable condition to prevent the attraction of pests and other vermin. Inedible waste, including butters contained in lined box and peanut skins collected in bulk containers, were stored and handled for animal feed and kept separate from other storage or processing. Waste water (sanitation) was collected via the floor drainage system and discharged to the municipal sewerage system. Screens were used to capture solids in the wastewater. The manufacturing facilities were primarily dry processing areas; water was only introduced to the areas during wet cleaning activities. Line audits, GMP audits, and pre-operational inspections were utilized to review the effectiveness of waste management program. Trademarked materials were destroyed prior to disposal.

- 4.8.1.1** The responsibility and methods used to collect and handle dry, wet, and liquid waste and how to store it prior to removal from the premises shall be documented and implemented.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.8.1.2** Waste shall be removed on a regular basis and not build up in pet food handling or processing areas. Designated waste accumulation areas shall be maintained in a clean and tidy condition until external waste collection is undertaken.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.8.1.3** Waste and overflow water from tubs, tanks, and other equipment shall be discharged direct to the floor drainage system, or an alternative method that meets local regulatory requirements.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.8.1.4** Trolleys, vehicle waste disposal equipment, collection bins, and storage areas shall be maintained in a serviceable condition, cleaned, and sanitized regularly so as not to attract pests and other vermin.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 4.8.1.5** Adequate provision shall be made for the disposal of all solid processing waste including trimmings, inedible material, and used packaging.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

4.8.1.6 Where applicable, a documented procedure shall be in place for the controlled disposal of trademarked materials or waste considered high-risk for handling or other reasons. Where a contracted disposal service is used, the disposal process shall be reviewed regularly to confirm compliance.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

4.8.1.7 Inedible waste designated for animal feed shall be stored and handled so that it will not cause a risk to the animal or to further processing. If denaturant is used to identify inedible waste, it shall be demonstrated that it does not pose a risk to animal health.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

4.8.1.8 Waste held on-site prior to disposal shall be stored in a separate storage facility and suitably insect proofed and contained so as not to present a hazard.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

4.8.1.9 Adequate provision shall be made for the disposal of all liquid waste from processing and pet food handling areas. Liquid waste shall be either removed from the processing environment continuously or held in a designated storage area in lidded containers prior to disposal so as not to present a hazard.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

4.8.1.10 Reviews of the effectiveness of waste management shall form part of regular site inspections (refer to 2.5.4.3) and the results of these inspections shall be included in the relevant inspection reports.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

11.1.1 Premises Location and Approval

The site's buildings, property and surroundings were properly designed and maintained and were not observed to pose a risk to food safety. The Main Site (older, original site by the town center) and Peanut Facility Site (new building located in a residential area a few blocks away) were located in Nunda, NY. The sites were surrounded by homes or commercial businesses. The Perry Warehouse was half of a commercial building in a commercial lot located in a small town 25 minutes away. External areas were included in the site's internal inspection program. The sites were approved by the relevant authorities, as evidenced by city business licenses and verification of the current FDA Bioterrorism registrations.

11.1.1.1 The site shall assess local activities and the site environment to identify any risks that may have an adverse impact on product safety and implement controls for any identified risks. The assessment shall be reviewed in response to any changes in the local environment or activities.
The construction and ongoing operation of the premises on the site shall be approved by the relevant authority.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

11.1.2 Building Materials

The design and maintenance of the manufacturing buildings met the high care requirements to mitigate food safety risks. Production and sanitation room floors at both sites were epoxy-coated, sanitation room floors were sloped to drains. Walls and ceilings at the peanut facility were steel panel or Insulated Steel Panels (ISP) and maintained in good condition. Upgrades to wall and ceiling rooms in the Main Site were noted from the previous year's audit (sesame roaster room). Other rooms were built as modular rooms with ISP panels. Floors were well maintained. The sanitation room drains were clean and in good condition. Rooms were segregated from other processing rooms and were dry-cleaned. Hand sinks were located at the entrance area to each room. Underground wastewater equalization tanks were used to collect wastewater prior to discharge to the city. Wall-floor junctions were designed to prevent build-up and noted as clean during the audit. Utility pipes were positioned away from direct contact from walls and ceilings and overhead equipment was maintained in good condition. Doors were of commercially designed materials and maintained to facilitate cleaning. Ceilings were clean and were not observed as a risk of potential contamination. Elevated processing platforms (blending) were designed not to present a risk of contamination; exposed products were not observed stored below stairs or ladders.

The site was not designed with sanitary waste lines located over processing or storage areas.

- 11.1.2.1** Floors shall be constructed of smooth, dense, impact-resistant material that can be effectively graded, drained, impervious to liquid, and easily cleaned. Floors shall be sloped to floor drains at gradients suitable to allow the effective removal of all overflow or wastewater under normal working conditions. Where floor drainage is not available, plumbed options to handle overflow or wastewater shall be in place.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.1.2.2** Drains shall be constructed and located so they can be easily cleaned and not present a hazard.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.1.2.3** Waste trap system shall be located away from any food handling areas or entrances to the premises.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.1.2.4** Walls, partitions, ceilings, and doors shall be of durable construction. Internal surfaces shall have an even and regular surface and be impervious with a light-colored finish and shall be kept clean (refer to 11.2.5). Wall-to-wall and wall-to-floor junctions shall be designed to be easily cleaned and sealed to prevent the accumulation of food debris.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.1.2.5** Ducting, conduit, and pipes that convey ingredients, products, or services, such as steam or water, shall be designed and constructed to prevent the contamination of food, ingredients, and food contact surfaces and allow ease of cleaning.
A risk analysis shall be conducted to ensure food contamination risks are mitigated.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.1.2.7** Doors, hatches, and windows and their frames in food processing, handling, or storage areas shall be of a material and construction that meets the same functional requirements as for internal walls and partitions. Doors and hatches shall be of solid construction, and windows shall be made of shatterproof glass or similar material.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.1.2.8** Product shall be processed and handled in areas that are fitted with a ceiling or other acceptable structure that is constructed and maintained to prevent the contamination of products. Drop ceilings, where present, shall be constructed to enable monitoring for pest activity, facilitate cleaning, and provide access to utilities.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.1.2.9** Stairs, catwalks, and platforms in food processing and handling areas shall be designed and constructed so they do not present a product-contamination risk and with no open grates directly above exposed food product surfaces. They shall be kept clean (refer to 11.2.5).

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

11.1.3 Lightings and Light Fittings

Light fittings in the Main site and Peanut Facility site were high-efficient LED bulbs in shatter resistant fixtures and were observed clean and in good condition. Light intensity was appropriate for the processing, sanitation, and inspection activities. Light fixtures in the coolers and warehouse areas were the same design as in processing rooms. Lighting in the offsite warehouse was a combination of LED and florescent. Light fixtures were protected in shatterproof bulbs and fixtures. No issues were observed with broken/damaged light fixtures or with lights not working.

- 11.1.3.1** Lighting in food processing and handling areas and at inspection stations shall be of appropriate intensity to enable the staff to carry out their tasks efficiently and effectively and shall comply with local light-intensity regulations or industry standards.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.1.3.2** Light fixtures in processing areas, inspection stations, ingredient and packaging storage areas, and all areas where the product is exposed shall be shatterproof, manufactured with a shatterproof covering or fitted with protective covers, and recessed into or fitted flush with the ceiling.

Where fixtures cannot be recessed, structures must be protected from accidental breakage, manufactured from cleanable materials, and addressed in the cleaning and sanitation program.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.1.3.3** Light fixtures in the warehouse or other areas where product is covered or otherwise protected shall be designed to prevent breakage and product contamination.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

11.1.4 Inspection/ Quality Control Area

Online inspections were not conducted. Packaging lines were equipped with auto-samplers and materials were removed from the floor prior to sampling / testing.

11.1.5 Dust, Insect, and Pest Proofing

The sites did not use windows or open ventilation in any process, packaging areas, or warehouse areas. External doors at each of the three sites were self-closing and observed in good condition. Seals around doors were close-fitting and prevented ingress. Dock cushions and overheads were in place to seal around trailers while loading and unloading. ILTs were located away from storage or processing rooms. Rodenticide was not stored.

- 11.1.5.1** All external windows, ventilation openings, doors, and other openings shall be effectively sealed when closed, and proofed against dust, vermin, and other pests.
- External personnel access doors shall be effectively insect-proofed and fitted with a self-closing device and proper seals to protect against entry of dust, vermin, and other pests.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.1.5.2** External doors, including overhead dock doors in food handling areas used for product, pedestrian, or truck access, shall be designed and maintained to prevent pest ingress by at least one or a combination of the following methods:
- i. A self-closing device;
 - ii. An effective air curtain;
 - iii. A pest-proof screen;
 - iv. A pest-proof annex; and
 - v. Adequate sealing around trucks in docking areas.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.1.5.3** Electric insect control devices, pheromone, or other traps and baits shall be located and operated so they do not present a contamination risk to the product, packaging, containers, or processing equipment. Poison rodenticide bait shall not be used inside ingredients or product storage areas or processing areas where ingredients, packaging, and products are handled, processed, or exposed.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

11.1.6 Ventilation

Filtered HVAC ventilation systems (Merv 11) were in place for the processing (roasting and open product RTE) rooms to remove dust and debris from the processing and packaging areas. Ventilation equipment was clean and insect-proofed; filter replacement was included in the PM schedule. Extractor fans on roasters were appropriately designed and included in the master cleaning schedules. No condensation was observed in any of the roasters. Exhaust vents were screened to prevent insects from entering the facility when not in use.

- 11.1.6.1** Adequate ventilation shall be provided in enclosed processing and food handling areas. Where appropriate, positive air-pressure systems shall be installed to prevent airborne contamination.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.1.6.2** All ventilation equipment and devices in product storage and handling areas shall be adequately cleaned as per 11.2.5 to prevent unsanitary conditions.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.1.6.3** Extractor fans and canopies shall be provided in areas where open cooking operations are carried out or a large amount of steam is generated. Capture velocities shall be sufficient to prevent condensation build-up and to evacuate all heat, fumes, and other aerosols to the exterior via an exhaust hood positioned over the cooker(s).

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.1.6.4** Fans and exhaust vents shall be insect-proofed and located so they do not pose a contamination risk and shall be kept clean.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

11.1.7 Equipment and Utensils

The General Manager worked with maintenance and had a list of design specification requirements (Equipment / Structure Fabrication Requirements) needed when purchasing or building equipment. Product design standards included stainless steel, COP wash-down, UHMW plastic, flexible vinyl conveyors, aluminum vacuum-transfer piping, and carbon steel (non-wash-down areas). QA maintained inspections on equipment installation and after repairs on the software program that was used. Regulatory design standards did not apply.

Tables, conveyors, tubs, and containers were designed, constructed, and installed to these same standards. The design and maintenance of the equipment prevented risks of cross-contamination. Equipment surfaces were smooth, impervious, and free from cracks and crevices. Bins and containers were made of non-toxic materials (Rubbermaid) and were color-coded for use. Fork trucks were electric. Maintenance was responsible for tagging out equipment found unfit for use with no equipment tag outs being observed during the audit.

Minor 11.1.7.4: A lid being used for the cashew pasteurizer hopper was observed with a closed-cell foam structure. A Lexan cover was used on the cashew mixer that was not secured away from the rotating shaft.

- 11.1.7.1** Specifications for equipment and utensils and procedures for purchasing equipment shall be documented and implemented.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.1.7.2** Equipment and utensils shall be designed, constructed, installed, operated, and maintained to meet any applicable regulatory requirements and to not pose a contamination threat to products.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.1.7.3** Equipment storage rooms shall be designed and constructed to allow for the hygienic and efficient storage of equipment and containers. Where possible, food contact equipment shall be segregated from non-food contact equipment.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.1.7.4** Product contact surfaces and those surfaces not in direct contact with food in food handling areas, raw material storage, packaging storage, and cold storage areas shall be constructed of materials that will not contribute to a food safety risk.

RESPONSE: MINOR

EVIDENCE: A lid being used for the cashew pasteurizer hopper was observed with a closed-cell foam structure. A Lexan cover was used on the cashew mixer that was not secured away from the rotating shaft.

ROOT CAUSE: Lid for cashew hopper was in place and appeared to be an acceptable non-porous material. Follow Equipment and Utensil Specification Policy - QMS-PLC0080 and design new cover.

Production applied Lexan cover to decrease exposure from foreign material entering the product stream.

CORRECTIVE ACTION: Destroy current lid for cashew hopper. Cover bin with temporary cover.

Removed Lexan bin cover away from mixer during audit.

VERIFICATION OF CLOSEOUT: Accepted, Mark Weighner

COMPLETION DATE: 05/09/2024 **CLOSEOUT DATE:** 05/12/2024

11.1.7.5 Benches, tables, conveyors, mixers, mincers, graders, and other mechanical processing equipment shall be hygienically designed and located for appropriate cleaning. Equipment surfaces shall be smooth, impervious, and free from cracks or crevices.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

11.1.7.6 Product containers, tubs, and bins used for edible and inedible material shall be constructed of materials that are non-toxic, smooth, impervious, and readily cleaned as per 11.2.5.1. Bins used for inedible material shall be clearly identified.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

11.1.7.7 All equipment and utensils shall be cleaned after use (refer to 11.2.5.1) or at a set and validated frequency to control contamination and be stored in a clean and serviceable condition to prevent microbiological or cross-contact allergen contamination.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

11.1.7.8 Vehicles used in food contact, handling, or processing zones or cold storage rooms shall be designed and operated so as not to present a food safety hazard.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.1.7.9** Non-conforming equipment shall be identified, tagged, and/or segregated for repair or disposal in a manner that minimizes the risk of inadvertent use, improper use, or risk to the integrity of finished product. Records of the handling, corrective action, and/or disposal of non-conforming equipment shall be maintained.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

11.1.8 Grounds and Roadways

The areas around each of the facilities were observed clean and maintained in good condition. Grassy areas were manicured, rock barriers were provided along the base of each of the buildings; no harborage areas were observed. The entry, parking lots, and the loading dock areas were hard surfaced and/or concrete, in good condition, and free of harborage or storage. The surfaces were sloped to prevent ponding. Standing water was not observed. Sidewalks to the site were concrete.

- 11.1.8.1** A suitable external environment shall be established, and the effectiveness of the measures shall be monitored and periodically reviewed. The premises, its surrounding areas, storage facilities, machinery, and equipment shall be kept free of waste or accumulated debris, and vegetation shall be controlled so as not to attract pests and vermin or present a food safety hazard to the sanitary operation of the site.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.1.8.2** Paths, roadways, and loading and unloading areas shall be maintained so as not to present a hazard to the food safety operations of the premises. They shall be adequately drained to prevent the pooling of water. Drains shall be separate from the site drainage system and regularly cleared of debris.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.1.8.3** Paths from amenities leading to site entrances shall be effectively sealed.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

11.2.1 Repairs and Maintenance

Maintenance was managed through a software program designed to manage maintenance activities. The software included the list of PMs that were due at any time. Work orders were provided with an expected due date and completed PM work orders regenerated themselves to the next due date based on the assigned frequency.

Maintenance was under the responsibility of the General Manager and maintenance completion/open activities were reviewed in weekly SQF meetings.

The process allowed anyone (supervisor or QA and above) to log in and request a work order.

The system in place for inspections on Priority 1 (food contact) after repair was to inspect the repair and record the inspection in the Quality Management Software.

Temporary repairs were allowed as long as they were logged into the maintenance repair log, they were not allowed to use unsafe materials (tape, wood, wire, cardboard, plastic), and they were fixed as soon as possible and tracked through the QA program.

Food grade and non-food grade lubricants were kept in separate cabinets and only food grade lubricants were used on production equipment. Product contact surfaces were not painted.

Minor 11.2.1.4: A requested repair on the squeeze pack line (maintenance work order 9258) stated the pump had to be disassembled and put back together correctly. The notification to the Production Supervisor and/or QA Supervisor was not recorded, and no Quality Management Inspection by QA had been completed during/after the repair, as required by the procedure.

- 11.2.1.1** The methods and responsibility for the maintenance and repair of plant, equipment, and buildings shall be documented, planned, and implemented in a manner that minimizes the risk of product, packaging, or equipment contamination.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.2.1.2** Routine maintenance of plant and equipment in any food processing, handling, or storage areas shall be performed according to a maintenance control schedule and recorded.
The maintenance schedule shall be prepared to include buildings, equipment, and other areas of the premises critical to the maintenance of product safety.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.2.1.3** Failures of plant and equipment in any food processing, handling, or storage areas shall be documented and reviewed, and their repair(s) incorporated into the maintenance control schedule.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.2.1.4** Site supervisors shall be notified when maintenance or repairs are to be undertaken in any processing, handling, or storage areas.

RESPONSE: MINOR

EVIDENCE: A requested repair on the squeeze pack line (maintenance work order 9258) stated the pump had to be disassembled and put back together correctly. The notification to the Production Supervisor and/or QA Supervisor was not recorded and no Quality Management Inspection by QA had been completed during/after the repair, as required by the procedure.

ROOT CAUSE: No procedure established detailing the activities to be followed during Maintenance or Repair work in production areas.

CORRECTIVE ACTION: Zone 1 Maintenance Form - QMS-FORM0194 didn't include all Zone 1 areas. Roasters, Fillers, and Capper areas were the only areas included on the form. Update form to include all Zone 1 areas.

VERIFICATION OF CLOSEOUT: Accepted, Mark Weighner

COMPLETION DATE: 05/09/2024 **CLOSEOUT DATE:** 05/12/2024

- 11.2.1.5** The maintenance supervisor and the site supervisor shall be informed if any repairs or maintenance activities pose a potential threat to product safety (e.g., pieces of electrical wire, damaged light fittings, and loose overhead fittings). When possible, maintenance is to be conducted outside operating times.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.2.1.6** Temporary repairs, where required, shall not pose a food safety risk and shall be included in routine inspections (refer to 2.5.4.3) and the cleaning program. There shall be a plan in place to address the completion of temporary repairs to ensure they do not become permanent solutions.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.2.1.7** Food contact equipment and equipment located over food contact equipment shall be lubricated with food-grade lubricant, and its use shall be controlled to minimize the contamination of the product.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.2.1.8** Paint used in a food handling or processing area shall be suitable for use, in good condition, and not be used on any product contact surfaces.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

11.2.2 Maintenance Staff and Contractors

Maintenance contractors were escorted by the maintenance staff. As part of signing in, the contractor had to acknowledge GMP and infectious disease conditions. Maintenance and contractors were required to remove tools and parts upon completion of work before sanitation would occur.

Any contractor maintenance activity in food contact areas would be cleaned as part of a wet clean (change-over) or would be required to be inspected by QA after completion of the repair.

- 11.2.2.1** Maintenance staff and contractors shall comply with the site's personnel and process hygiene requirements (refer to 11.3).

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.2.2.2** All maintenance and other engineering contractors required to work on-site shall be trained in the site's food safety and hygiene procedures or shall be escorted at all times until their work is completed.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.2.2.3** Maintenance staff and contractors shall remove all tools and debris from any maintenance activity once it has been completed, and inform the area supervisor and maintenance supervisor, so appropriate hygiene and sanitation can be conducted and a pre-operational inspection completed prior to the restarting of site operations.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

11.2.3 Calibration

Calibration was the responsibility of QA and maintenance. Calibration records included a Calibration Schedule. This schedule identified the instrument's model, location, plant ID, and test results. Calibration records on a new metal detector installation 1/30/2024, and calibration certificates for annual Metal Detector Calibrations 12/15/2023 (supplier specification calibration) were provided. Scales 6/23/2023 (no failures were recorded), and aflatoxin Testers 3/28/24.

RTD - Roasters - 4/12/2024 and Magnets - 4/2/2024 were included in the program.

Equipment was calibrated against supplier specifications and NIST; no regulatory requirements of calibration applied.

Calibration failures were addressed in the program. The procedure listed the site's responsibility to address product disposition by QA should equipment be found out of calibration. Equipment was protected from damage and from unauthorized adjustments.

- 11.2.3.1** The methods and responsibility for calibration and re-calibration of measuring, testing, and inspection equipment used for monitoring activities outlined in prerequisite programs, food safety plans, and other process controls, or to demonstrate compliance with customer specifications, shall be documented and implemented. Software used for such activities shall be validated as appropriate.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.2.3.2** Equipment shall be calibrated against national or international reference standards and methods or to an accuracy appropriate to its use. In cases where standards are not available, the site shall provide evidence to support the calibration reference method applied.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.2.3.3** Calibration shall be performed according to regulatory requirements and/or to the equipment manufacturers' recommended schedule.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.2.3.4** Procedures shall be documented and implemented to address the resolution of potentially affected products when measuring, testing, or inspection equipment is found to be out of calibration.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.2.3.5** Calibrated measuring, testing, and inspection equipment shall be protected from damage and unauthorized adjustment or use.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.2.3.6** A directory of measuring, testing, and inspection equipment that require calibration and records of the calibration tests shall be maintained.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

11.2.4 Pest Prevention

Pest control was managed through a third party PCO - the contract was reviewed / signed annually (1/29/2024). Pest control at the three sites was managed under the same agreement and included weekly inspections, interior rodent traps, ILT checks, and pheromone checks. The plan included monthly exterior bait station treatments and as-needed exterior perimeter treatments. Documents reviewed in the Pest Logbook were the PCO Business License (8/31/2026), Certificate of Insurance (10/1/2024), Applicator License (4/21/2024), list of Authorized Products (1/29/2024), Pest Control Material Authorization for Organic Facilities (1/29/2024), and SDS for each approved chemical. The Device Map was reviewed annually (3/11/2024) and a Pest Sighting Log was maintained by the site.

Reviewed Pest Inspection Reports (printed hard copy) from 4/15/2024, 4/2/2025, 2/5/24, and 1/29/24 with the reports being signed by the SQF Practitioner. The report format included a Recommendations tracker - a recommendation on floor cracks were signed off by the PCO on 4/5/2024. The PCO provided a summary of each visit as the last decision in each report.

A PCO QA Audit was completed by the pest control management team on 3/18/2024. The audit included a site inspection and made no recommendations for changes. The Quarterly Pest Activity Trend Report was included at the back of the Logbook with trends within listed thresholds. The areas were observed clean and free of harborage during the audit.

The site maintained the list of observations on their QA software program and tracked them through to completion. Examples of Closed Cases were provided during the audit included sealing up cracks around inlet augers in the peanut facility. The site did not store pesticides.

Minor 11.2.4.2: A can of Raid was observed in a janitorial cabinet at the Perry warehouse.

- 11.2.4.1** A documented pest prevention program shall be effectively implemented. It shall:
- i. Describe the methods and responsibility for the development, implementation, and maintenance of the pest prevention program;
 - ii. Record pest sightings and trend the frequency of pest activity to target pesticide applications;
 - iii. Outline the methods used to prevent pest problems;
 - iv. Outline the pest elimination methods and the appropriate documentation for each inspection;
 - v. Outline the frequency with which pest status is to be checked;
 - vi. Include the identification, location, number, and type of applied pest control/monitoring devices on a site map;
 - vii. List the chemicals used. The chemicals are required to be approved by the relevant authority and their Safety Data Sheets (SDS) made available;
 - viii. Outline the methods used to make staff aware of the bait control program and the measures to take when they come into contact with a bait station;
 - ix. Outline the requirements for staff awareness and training in the use of pest and vermin control chemicals and baits; and
 - x. Measure the effectiveness of the program to verify the elimination of applicable pests and to identify trends.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.2.4.2** Pest contractors and/or internal pest controllers shall:
- i. Be licensed and approved by the local relevant authority;
 - ii. Use only trained and qualified operators, who comply with regulatory requirements;
 - iii. Use only approved chemicals;
 - iv. Provide a pest prevention plan (refer to 2.3.2.8), which includes a site map, indicating the location of bait stations traps and other applicable pest control/monitoring devices;
 - v. Report to a responsible authorized person on entering the premises and after the completion of inspections or treatments;
 - vi. Provide regular inspections for pest activity with appropriate action taken if pests are present, and
 - vii. Provide a written report of their findings and the inspections and treatments applied.

RESPONSE: MINOR

EVIDENCE: A can of Raid was observed in a janitorial cabinet at the Perry warehouse.

ROOT CAUSE: Training form didn't include any questions revolving around the use of pesticides in the facility.

CORRECTIVE ACTION: Removed can from facility.

VERIFICATION OF CLOSEOUT: Accepted, Mark Weighner

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- 11.2.4.3** Pest activity risks shall be analyzed and recorded. Inspections for pest activity shall be conducted on a regular basis by trained site personnel and the appropriate action taken if pests are present. Identified pest activity shall not present a risk of contamination to food products, raw materials, or packaging. Records of all pest control inspections and applications shall be maintained.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

11.2.4.4 Food products, raw materials, or packaging that are found to be contaminated by pest activity shall be effectively disposed of, and the source of pest infestation shall be investigated and resolved. Records shall be kept of the disposal, investigation, and resolution.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

11.2.4.6 No animals shall be permitted on-site in food handling and storage areas.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

11.2.5 Cleaning and Sanitation

Master Cleaning records were maintained on Google Sheets for each of the three sites and handheld tablets were provided for employees to record the completed work. The cleaning schedule was broken down to the specific tasks required in each room. QA had responsibility for verifying completion and providing a % Completion Score in weekly SQF Meeting. Records were complete and completion rates for the past 6 months showed typical completion rates >80%, which was the stated objective. The score card was programed to report each area and coded for green cells to be in spec, yellow cells listed as a warning, and red cells listed as a failure. For food contact parts, COP tanks were used for cleaning. Cleaning records on COP included time, temp, and titration of the sanitizer being used. Records were captured in the electronic QA Software program. Titrations of the detergent and sanitizer were listed for each batch with a picture of the COP Chart taken when completed. Chemical training records were requested (jb, gg, bl) and reviewed. Each cleaning record was electronically verified by QA after completion.

No CIP was used.

Cleaning equipment was stored on designated racks and hooks. Equipment was observed to be clean and free of damage.

Each plant used a "Drying room". Cleaned equipment was stored clean and on racks in these heated rooms to drive out any residual water in the equipment prior to use. Dryer rooms were maintained >95F.

Pre-Op inspections were tracked on an excel log and data was embedded in the ATP reader. QA conducted the visual inspections and conducted ATP checks after each cleaning (monthly shutdown). Reviewed the inspections/pre-op for the last two inspections 4/3/2024 through 4/8/2024 that were conducted after the monthly deep clean - each of the checks were in limit. Randomly reviewed completed pre-ops for the past 6 months and excel logs appeared up to date.

Janitorial cleaning (break rooms, toilet rooms, locker rooms) was cleaned by a contracted cleaning service. Completed MCS were posted/completed by the service provider.

11.2.5.1 The methods and responsibility for the effective cleaning of the food handling and processing equipment and environment and storage areas shall be documented and implemented. Consideration shall be given to:

- i. What is to be cleaned;
- ii. How it is to be cleaned;
- iii. When it is to be cleaned;
- iv. Who is responsible for the cleaning;
- v. Validation of the cleaning procedures for food contact surfaces (including CIP);
- vi. Methods used to confirm the correct concentrations of detergents and sanitizers; and
- vii. The responsibility and methods used to verify the effectiveness of the cleaning and sanitation program.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.2.5.2** Detergents and sanitizers shall be suitable for use in a food manufacturing environment, labeled according to regulatory requirements, and purchased in accordance with applicable legislation. The organization shall ensure:
- i. The site maintains a list of chemicals approved for use;
 - ii. An inventory of all purchased and used chemicals is maintained;
 - iii. Detergents and sanitizers are stored as outlined in element 11.6.4;
 - iv. Safety Data Sheets (SDS) are provided for all detergents and sanitizers purchased; and
 - v. Only trained staff handle sanitizers and detergents.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.2.5.3** Detergents and sanitizers that have been mixed for use shall be correctly mixed according to the manufacturers' instructions, stored in containers that are suitable for use, and clearly identified. Mix concentrations shall be verified and records maintained.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.2.5.5** Cleaning equipment, tools, racks, and other items used in support of the cleaning and sanitizing program shall be clearly identified, stored, and maintained in a manner that prevents contamination of processing areas, product handling equipment, and storage areas as well as the tools themselves.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.2.5.6** Suitably equipped areas shall be designated for cleaning product containers, knives, cutting boards, and other utensils used by staff. The areas for these cleaning operations shall be controlled so they do not interfere with manufacturing operations, equipment, or product. Racks and containers for storing cleaned utensils shall be provided as required.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.2.5.7** Pre-operational inspections shall be conducted following cleaning and sanitation operations to ensure food processing areas, product contact surfaces, equipment, staff amenities, sanitary facilities, and other essential areas are clean before the start of production. Pre-operational inspections shall be conducted by qualified personnel.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.2.5.8** Staff amenities, sanitary facilities, and other essential areas shall be inspected by qualified personnel at a defined frequency to ensure the areas are clean.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.2.5.9** The responsibility and methods used to verify the effectiveness of the cleaning procedures shall be documented and implemented. A verification schedule shall be prepared.
A record of pre-operational hygiene inspections, cleaning and sanitation activities, and verification activities shall be maintained.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

11.3.1 Personnel Welfare

The policy Illness Reporting (4/12/23) was in place and trained contractors, visitors, and employees (at hire and annually). The policy included annual sign-off, monitoring of employee health through supervisor observations (daily), and though daily QA Line Audits. Inspections included employee practices such as handwashing, proper wearing of hairnets and proper uniforms, and ensuring employees did not appear ill. The GMP policy that was used for employee training and for GMP inspections called out employee health as a concern that had to be reported to HR.

The employee GMP required the use of metal detector bandages (bandages were tested monthly in a metal detector). In open food areas, employees were required to wear uniforms and supervisors/managers wore smocks; food handler gloves were used when handling products or product-contact areas. Bodily fluid spill kits were provided with emergency supply cabinets located in the facility.

- 11.3.1.1** Personnel who are known to be carriers of infectious diseases that present a health risk to others through the packing or storage processes shall not engage in the processing or packing of food or enter storage areas where food is exposed.

Code Amendment #1

A medical screening procedure shall be in place for all employees, visitors and contractors who handle exposed product or food contact surfaces.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.3.1.2** The site shall have measures in place to prevent contact of materials, ingredients, food packaging, food, or food contact surfaces from any bodily fluids, open wounds, coughing, sneezing, spitting, or any other means.
In the event of an injury that causes the spillage of bodily fluid, a properly trained staff member shall ensure that all affected areas, including handling and processing areas, have been adequately cleaned, and that all materials and products have been quarantined and/or disposed of.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.3.1.3** Personnel with exposed cuts, sores, or lesions shall not engage in handling or processing exposed products or handling primary (food contact) packaging or touching food contact surfaces. Minor cuts or abrasions on exposed parts of the body shall be covered with a colored, metal-detectable bandage or an alternative suitable waterproof and colored dressing.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

11.3.2 Handwashing

The enforced hand washing policy required any employee or visitor to wash hands prior to entry to any processing or packaging rooms. Hand wash basins were provided. Boots were taken captive to the processing/packaging room and visitors were required to wear booties provided by management. Hand wash sinks were located just outside each production/packaging room and were constructed of stainless steel, had hands-free water, hands-free liquid soap and towels. Hand sanitizer stations were positioned at each process entry for sanitizing hands. Hand wash reminder signs were posted at the exit of each toilet room, at the exit of the locker area, at the exit of the break rooms, and at the entrance to the site. Employees were observed washing their hands and using proper gowning procedures (boots, hairnets, handwashing, smocks, and gloving) during the audit.

- 11.3.2.1** All personnel shall have clean hands, and hands shall be washed by all staff, contractors, and visitors:
- i. On entering food handling or processing areas;
 - ii. After each visit to a toilet;
 - iii. After using a handkerchief;
 - iv. After smoking, eating, or drinking; and
 - v. After handling wash down hoses, cleaning materials, dropped product, or contaminated material.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.3.2.2** Handwashing stations shall be provided adjacent to all personnel access points and in accessible locations throughout food handling and processing areas as required.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.3.2.3** Handwashing stations shall be constructed of stainless steel or similar non-corrosive material and at a minimum supplied with:
- i. A potable water supply at an appropriate temperature;
 - ii. Liquid soap contained within a fixed dispenser;
 - iii. Paper towels in a hands-free cleanable dispenser; and
 - iv. A means of containing used paper towels.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.3.2.4** The following additional facilities shall be provided in high-risk areas:
- i. Hands-free operated taps; and
 - ii. Hand sanitizers.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.3.2.5** Signage in appropriate languages instructing people to wash their hands before entering the food processing areas shall be provided in a prominent position in break rooms, at break room exits, toilet rooms, and in outside eating areas, as applicable.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

11.3.2.6 When gloves are used, personnel shall maintain the handwashing practices outlined above.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

11.3.3 Clothing and Personal Effects

A risk analysis of PPE and clothing requirements was completed and provided by QA. Laundered uniform and hair restraint requirements were in place to protect materials, food, and food contact surfaces from unintentional microbiological or allergen cross-contamination. Personnel were required to wear a company provided uniform (shirt & pants) and managers/ supervisors wore a smock outer garment over appropriate street clothing in any production or storage areas of the Main and Peanut Facilities. Uniforms and smocks were laundered by an approved service supplier and stored on racks located in the locker rooms. Shoes were captive to the production facilities and visitors were required to wear disposable smocks and booties while in the plant. Excessively soiled uniforms could be changed or replaced, when necessary. Disposable smocks, different color hairnet, and booties were provided for non-raw-process employees and visitors entering the raw side of the plant. An ante room was used between the two sides for changing uniforms. Hooks were located nearby or adjacent to the personnel access doorways and handwashing facilities for the temporary storage of protective clothing when personnel left processing areas. Employees handling food or food contact were required to wear single use, disposable gloves. Jewelry, with the exception of plain bands with no stones, prescribed medical alert jewelry, and other loose objects were not permitted to be worn or taken into a food handling or processing operation or into any area where food is exposed.

11.3.3.1 The site shall undertake a risk analysis to ensure that the clothing and hair policy protects materials, food, and food contact surfaces from unintentional microbiological or physical contamination.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

11.3.3.2 Clothing worn by staff engaged in handling food shall be maintained, stored, laundered, and worn so it does not present a contamination risk to products.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

11.3.3.3 Clothing, including shoes, shall be clean at the start of each shift and maintained in a serviceable condition.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

11.3.3.4 Excessively soiled uniforms shall be changed or replaced when they present a product contamination risk.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.3.3.5** Disposable gloves and aprons shall be changed after each break, upon re-entry into the processing area, and when damaged.
Non-disposable aprons and gloves shall be cleaned and sanitized as required and when not in use stored on racks provided in the processing area or in designated sealed containers in personnel lockers. They should not be placed or stored on packaging, ingredients, product, or equipment.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.3.3.6** Protective clothing shall be manufactured from material that will not pose a food safety threat and is easily cleaned.
All protective clothing shall be cleaned after use, or at a frequency to control contamination, and stored in a clean and serviceable condition to prevent microbiological or cross-contact allergen contamination.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.3.3.7** Racks shall be provided for the temporary storage of protective clothing when staff leave the processing area and shall be provided nearby or adjacent to the personnel access doorways and handwashing facilities.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.3.3.8** Jewelry and other loose objects shall not be worn or taken into a food handling or processing operation or into any area where food is exposed. Wearing plain bands with no stones, prescribed medical alert bracelets, or jewelry accepted for religious or cultural reasons can be permitted, provided these items are properly covered and do not pose a food safety risk.
All exceptions shall meet regulatory and customer requirements and shall be subject to a risk assessment and evidence of ongoing risk management.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

11.3.4 Visitors

Visitors and management staff were required to comply with the requirements of the site's GMP policy. This policy included the wearing of appropriate smocks/hairnets, acknowledgement of not having communicable food-borne disease or illness, entering and exiting food handling areas through designated entrance points, and to comply with the hand washing and personnel practice requirements. Visitors were required to wear disposable smocks and booties and were escorted while in any food processing, handling and storage areas.

- 11.3.4.1** All visitors shall be trained in the site's food safety and hygiene procedures before entering any food processing and handling areas or shall be escorted at all times in food processing, handling, and storage areas.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

11.3.4.2 All visitors, including management staff, shall be required to remove jewelry and other loose objects in accordance with the facilities Good Manufacturing Practices and 11.3.3.8. All visitors shall wear suitable clothing and footwear when entering any food processing and handling area.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

11.3.4.3 Visitors exhibiting visible signs of illness shall be prevented from entering areas in which food is handled and processed.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

11.3.4.4 Visitors shall enter and exit food handling areas through the proper staff entrance points and comply with all handwashing and personnel practice requirements.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

11.3.5 Staff Amenities (change rooms, toilet, break rooms)

Staff amenities included a raw side break room (peanut facility), RTE side breakroom, locker areas, toilet rooms, and offices. Amenity areas were well lit, clean, and in good condition. RTE rooms (majority of processing in the peanut and main facilities) maintained separation from raw peanut storage or processing. Employees were provided with personal lockers to store their outdoor clothing and personal items. Showers were provided, but not required. Toilet rooms were adequately designed and built for the number of employees; they were observed clean and properly maintained.

Hand wash basins supplied with warm potable water, liquid soap, paper towels and sanitizer. Hand wash reminder signs were posted in the break rooms, toilet rooms, at each hand sink, and at the entrance area. Sanitary drainage was separate from any process drains and was connected directly to municipal sewerage system. The lunch/break rooms were segregated from the food processing, handling and storage areas. Lunchrooms were sufficient in size for the number of employees working at each facility. Lunchrooms included hot/cold potable water, refrigerators, microwave ovens, and were observed cleaned and maintained. Small outside eating and smoking areas were kept clean and free from waste.

11.3.5.1 Staff amenities shall have documented cleaning procedures, be supplied with appropriate lighting and ventilation, and shall be made available for use by all persons engaged in the handling and processing of product.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

11.3.5.2 Change rooms shall be provided to enable staff and visitors to change into and out of protective clothing as required. Change rooms shall be kept clean.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

11.3.5.3 High-risk change areas shall be provided for staff engaged in the processing of high-risk foods or processing operations in which clothing can be soiled.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.3.5.4** Provision shall be made for staff to store their street clothing and personal items separate from clean uniforms, food contact zones, food, and packaging storage areas.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.3.5.5** Where required, a sufficient number of showers shall be provided for use by staff.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.3.5.6** Toilet rooms shall be:
- i. Designed and constructed so that they are accessible to staff and separate from any processing and food handling operations;
 - ii. Accessed from the processing area via an airlock vented to the exterior or through an adjoining room;
 - iii. Sufficient in number for the maximum number of staff;
 - iv. Constructed so that they can be easily cleaned and maintained;
 - v. Located inside or nearby areas for storing protective clothing, outer garments, and other items while using the facilities; and
 - vi. Kept clean and tidy.
- Tools/equipment used for cleaning toilet rooms shall not be used to clean processing areas.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.3.5.7** Sanitary drainage shall not be connected to any other drains within the premises and shall be directed to a septic tank or a sewerage system in accordance with regulations.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.3.5.8** Handwashing basins shall be provided immediately outside or inside the toilet room and designed as outlined in 11.3.2.3.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.3.5.9** Separate break rooms shall be provided away from food contact/handling zones.
- Break rooms shall be:
- i. Ventilated and well lit;
 - ii. Provided with adequate tables and seating to cater for the maximum number of staff at one sitting;
 - iii. Equipped with a sink serviced with hot and cold potable water for washing utensils;
 - iv. Equipped with refrigeration and heating facilities, enabling staff to store or heat food and to prepare non-alcoholic beverages if required; and
 - v. Kept clean and free from waste materials and pests.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.3.5.10** Where outside eating areas are provided, they should be kept clean and free from waste materials and maintained in a manner that minimizes the potential for the introduction of contamination, including pests to the site.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

11.4.1 Staff Engaged in Food Handling and Processing Operations

Workers were required to wear hairnets and beard nets (if applicable) when entering food processing or handling areas. Smoking, chewing, eating, or spitting was not permitted in process or storage area. Employees were observed complying with these restrictions during the audit. Smoking, including the use of e-cigarettes, was restricted to designated outside smoking areas. Drinking water coolers and the use of company issued drinking water containers was permitted in the food processing, handling or storage areas of the facility. The flow of personnel-maintained separation from raw/RTE and addressed allergen cross-contamination in a manner that minimized product risk.

Sensory evaluations were conducted in hallway areas and away from open products. Inspection desks were located next to handwashing sinks. Packaging leads and operators were trained in sensory testing and hygiene requirements. Sampling procedures were posted and included taking samples off the line, products were tasted using sterile tongue depressors, used tongue depressor were disposed of in the trash receptacle, and employees were required to wash and sanitize their hands prior to returning to the production line.

- 11.4.1.1** All personnel engaged in any food handling, preparation, or processing operations shall ensure that products and materials are handled and stored in such a way as to prevent damage or product contamination. They shall comply with the following processing practices:
- i. Personnel entry to processing areas shall be through the personnel access doors only;
 - ii. All doors are to be kept closed. Doors shall not be open for extended periods when access is required for waste removal or receiving of product/ingredient/packaging;
 - iii. Packaging, product, and ingredients shall be kept in appropriate containers as required and off the floor;
 - iv. Waste shall be contained in the bins identified for this purpose and removed from the processing area on a regular basis and not left to accumulate; and
 - v. All wash down and compressed air hoses shall be stored on hose racks after use and not left on the floor.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.4.1.2** Personnel working in or visiting food handling or processing operations shall ensure that:
- i. Staff shall not eat or taste any product being processed in the food handling/contact zones, except as noted in element 11.4.1.4;
 - ii. The wearing of false fingernails, false eyelashes, eyelash extensions, long nails, or fingernail polish is not permitted when handling exposed food;
 - iii. Hair restraints and beard covers, where applicable, shall be used in areas where product is exposed.
 - iv. Smoking, chewing, eating, or spitting is not permitted in areas where product is produced, stored, or otherwise exposed.
 - v. Drinking water is permissible only under conditions that prevent contamination or other food safety risks from occurring. Drinking water containers in production and storage areas shall be stored in clear, covered containers, and in designated areas away from raw materials, packaging, tools, or equipment storage.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.4.1.3** The flow of personnel in food processing and handling areas shall be managed such that the potential for contamination is minimized.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.4.1.4** In circumstances where it is necessary to undertake sensory evaluations in a food handling/contact zone, the site shall implement controls and procedures to ensure:
- i. Food safety is not compromised;
 - ii. Sensory evaluations are conducted by authorized personnel only;
 - iii. A high standard of personal hygiene is practiced by personnel conducting sensory evaluations;
 - iv. Sensory evaluations are conducted in areas equipped for the purpose; and
 - v. Equipment used for sensory evaluations is sanitized, maintained, and stored separately from processing equipment.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

11.5.1 Water Supply

The water was from the local municipality. The city provided the site monthly reports on testing results (reviewed reports for 2023-2024 from samples taken at different areas throughout the city). The city water report included microbiological analysis and heavy metal and chemical analysis results. Hot water was supplied from a large water heater (the site did not use a commercial boiler). The temperature of water for each COP wash provided evidence of adequate supply of hot water. Backflow prevention testing (12/19/2023) were provided for the Peanut Facility and the Main Facility- results were listed as Pass. Non-potable water was not utilized. Water was not stored.

- 11.5.1.1** Adequate supplies of potable water drawn from a known clean source shall be provided for water used as an ingredient during processing operations and for cleaning the premises and equipment. The source of potable water shall be identified as well as on-site storage (if applicable) and reticulation within the facility.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.5.1.2** Contingency plans shall be in place for instances when the potable water supply is deemed to be contaminated or otherwise inappropriate for use.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.5.1.3** Supplies of hot and cold water shall be provided, as required, to enable the effective cleaning of the premises and equipment.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.5.1.4** The delivery of water within the premises shall ensure potable water is not contaminated. Testing of the backflow system, where possible, shall be conducted at least annually and records shall be maintained.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.5.2** **Water Treatment**
Water was not treated.

- 11.5.3** **Water Quality**
Water was used for monthly deep cleaning activities and for amenities. Water was not part of any processing. The city provided monthly water testing reports for different sites that were tested around the municipality each month.
In addition to the city testing, the site conducted annual testing of water to include chlorine, copper, lead, coliform, and E. coli using a 17025 Laboratory. The last test was completed 1/15/2024 for each site. Results were available for review.

- 11.5.3.1** Water shall comply with local, national, or internationally recognized potable water microbiological and quality standards, as required when used for:
- i. Washing, thawing, and treating food;
 - ii. Handwashing;
 - iii. Conveying food;
 - iv. An ingredient or food processing aid;
 - v. Cleaning food contact surfaces and equipment;
 - vi. The manufacture of ice; or
 - vii. The manufacture of steam that will come into contact with food or be used to heat water that will come into contact with food.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.5.3.2** Microbiological analysis of the water and ice supply shall be conducted to verify the cleanliness of the supply, the monitoring activities, and the effectiveness of the treatment measures implemented. Samples for analysis shall be taken at sources supplying water for the process or cleaning or from within the site. The frequency of analysis shall be risk-based and at a minimum annually.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

11.5.4 Ice Supply

Ice was not used.

11.5.5 Air and Other Gasses

Compressed air was used for cleaning jars prior to filling.

Compressed air was sampled/tested annually through an air sampler system. The last check on compressed air was completed 12/6/2023 for Yeast and Mold, results were between ND and 8 for each of the 8 completed checks. Compressed gas was not used in packaging.

- 11.5.5.1** Compressed air or other gases (e.g., nitrogen or carbon dioxide) that contact food or food contact surfaces shall be clean and present no risk to food safety.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.5.5.2** Compressed air systems and systems used to store or dispense other gases that come into contact with food or food contact surfaces shall be maintained and regularly monitored for quality and applicable food safety hazards. The frequency of analysis shall be risk-based and at a minimum annually.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

11.6.1 Receipt, Storage and Handling of Goods

Materials were stored in totes and Kraft bags on pallets and were kept off the floors and in safe and hygienic condition. Raw peanuts were cleaned, roasted, and stored in stainless steel silos prior to processing. Equipment was stored clean and covered when not in use. Chemicals were stored in secured cabinets. Dock doors were cushioned and protected products while loading/unloading. Cooler condensers were drained and kept free from dripping. Ingredients, raw materials, processing aids, and packaging were observed properly stored to minimize cross contamination risks.

Unprocessed raw materials were received and stored separately from processed raw materials to avoid cross-contamination risk. A new computerized inventory management system (ERP) was utilized to ensure effective FIFO rotation. No expired raw materials, ingredients, packaging materials or finished products were observed in the storage or production areas during the duration of the audit. Raw materials, ingredients, packaging, equipment, chemicals, or finished products were not held under temporary or overflow conditions.

Materials were not held under temporary conditions.

- 11.6.1.1** The site shall document and implement an effective storage plan that allows for the safe, hygienic receipt and storage of raw materials (i.e., frozen, chilled, and ambient), ingredients, packaging, equipment, and chemicals.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.6.1.2** Controls shall be in place to ensure all ingredients, raw materials, processing aids, and packaging are received and stored properly to prevent cross-contamination risks. Unprocessed raw materials shall be received and stored separately from processed raw materials to avoid cross-contamination risk.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.6.1.3** The responsibility and methods for ensuring effective stock rotation principles shall be documented and implemented.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.6.1.4** Procedures shall be in place to ensure that all ingredients, materials, work- in-progress, rework, and finished product are utilized within their designated shelf-life.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

11.6.2 Cold Storage, Freezing and Chilling of Foods

The Main Facility and the warehouse each maintained a small cooler. Coolers were in place for quality and shelf life for pasteurized tree nuts. Forms were provided electronically by QA on the electronic software, checks were conducted daily for temperature and humidity and QA would be provided an automatic email alert if results were out of the allowed limits. The coolers were clean and in good condition during the audit.

- 11.6.2.1** The site shall provide confirmation of the effective operational performance of freezing, chilling, and cold storage facilities. Chillers, blast freezers, and cold storage rooms shall be designed and constructed to allow for the hygienic and efficient refrigeration of food and be easily accessible for inspection and cleaning.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.6.2.2** Sufficient refrigeration capacity shall be available to chill, freeze, store chilled, or store frozen the maximum anticipated throughput of product with allowance for periodic cleaning of refrigerated areas.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.6.2.3** The site shall have a written procedure for monitoring temperatures, including the frequency of checks, and corrective actions, if the temperature is out of specification.
Freezing, chilling, and cold storage rooms shall be fitted with temperature monitoring equipment that is located to monitor the warmest part of the room and be fitted with a temperature measurement device that is easily readable and accessible. Records shall be kept of frozen, cold, and chilled storage room temperatures.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.6.2.4** Discharge from defrost and condensate lines shall be controlled and discharged into the drainage system.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

11.6.3 Storage of Dry Ingredients, Packaging, and Shelf Stable Packaged Goods

Storage areas for ingredients, packaging, and other dry goods were located away from wet areas. Warehouse racks were constructed to protect the materials from contamination and deterioration. Storage areas were clean and maintained to prevent harborage. Master Cleaning Schedules and Inspections included floor areas and behind racking. Storage area cleaning requirements were detailed in the completed master cleaning schedules (Google Sheets) provided during the audit. These areas were clean and organized during the audit.

- 11.6.3.1** Rooms used for the storage of product ingredients, packaging, and other dry goods shall be located away from wet areas and constructed to protect the product from contamination and deterioration and prevent packaging from becoming a harborage for pests or vermin.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.6.3.2** Racks provided for the storage of packaging shall be constructed of impervious materials and designed to enable cleaning and inspection of the floors and behind the racks. Storage areas shall be cleaned at a pre-determined frequency.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

11.6.4 Storage of Hazardous Chemicals and Toxic Substances

Chemicals were observed clearly labeled. Sanitizers were diluted for use and provided for line operators. The sanitation chemical register was used to track chemical usage. SDS logbooks were maintained by QA and were made available to employees. Maintenance shops kept food and non-food chemicals stored in separate labeled cabinets. Sanitation chemicals were kept in locked supply rooms next to the sanitation rooms. Processing utensils and packaging materials were not stored in areas used to store chemicals. Chemicals were labeled for use in food processing facilities. Daily supplies of chemicals (alcohol sanitizer) were appropriately labeled and stored. Personnel were trained in handling chemicals as part of annual training requirements. Spill kits, first aid equipment and personnel protective equipment (PPE) were provided in storage areas. Empty containers were triple rinsed, segregated and stored for pick-up.

- 11.6.4.1** Hazardous chemicals and toxic substances with the potential for food contamination shall be:
- i. Clearly labeled, identifying and matching the contents of their containers;
 - ii. Included in a current register of all hazardous chemicals and toxic substances that are stored on-site; and
 - iii. Supplemented with current Safety Data Sheets (SDS) made available to all staff.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.6.4.2** Storage of hazardous chemicals and toxic substances shall be:
- i. Located in an area with appropriate signage indicating that the area is for hazardous storage;
 - ii. Controlled, lockable, and accessible only by personnel trained in the storage and use of chemicals;
 - iii. Adequately ventilated;
 - iv. Stored where intended and not comingled (e.g., food versus non-food grade);
 - v. Designed such that pesticides, rodenticides, fumigants, and insecticides are stored separately from sanitizers and detergents; and
 - vi. Stored in a manner that prevents a hazard to finished product or product contact surfaces.
- Processing utensils and packaging shall not be stored in areas used to store hazardous chemicals and toxic substances.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.6.4.3** Hazardous chemicals and toxic substances shall be correctly labeled and:
- i. Used only according to manufacturers' instructions;
 - ii. Controlled to prevent contamination or a hazard to raw and packaging material, work-inprogress, finished product, or product contact surfaces;
 - iii. Returned to the appropriate storage areas after use; and
 - iv. Be compliant with national and local legislation.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.6.4.4** Daily supplies of chemicals used for continuous sanitizing of water, as a processing aid, or for emergency cleaning of food processing equipment and surfaces in food contact zones may be stored within or in close proximity to a processing area, provided that access to the chemical storage facility is restricted to only authorized personnel.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.6.4.5** Personnel who handle hazardous chemicals and toxic substances, including pesticides and cleaning chemicals,:
- i. Shall be fully trained in the purpose of the hazardous chemicals and toxic substances, their storage, handling, and use;
 - ii. Be provided first aid equipment and personnel protective equipment (PPE); and
 - iii. Ensure compliance with the proper identification, storage, usage, disposal, and clean-up requirements.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.6.4.6** The site shall dispose of empty, obsolete, and unused chemicals, pesticides, toxic substances, and containers in accordance with requirements and ensure that primary containers are:
- i. Not reused;
 - ii. Segregated and securely stored prior to collection; and
 - iii. Disposed through an approved vendor.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.6.4.7** In the event of a hazardous spill, the site shall:
- i. Have spillage clean-up instructions to ensure that the spill is properly contained; and
 - ii. Be equipped with PPE, spillage kits, and cleaning equipment.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

11.6.5 Loading, Transport, and Unloading Practices

Written procedures (QMS-PRC0035, QMS-PRC0037) detailed the requirements of how each processing site used the offsite warehouse for ingredients and finished products. The site maintained a tractor and several trailers that were used to shuttle between processing facilities and the warehouse. The warehouse used doors on opposite sides of the building for shuttle trailers on one side and outbound finished product orders on the other. The trailers used for transporting between the sites were maintained per the Drop Trailer Cleaning & Inspection Log inspected prior to loading to ensure they were clean, in good repair, suitable for the purpose, and free from odors or other conditions. The Inbound Clean Truck Affidavit was used to document the inspection of the trailers used to transport products between the manufacturing facilities and the off-site warehouse. The Outbound Clean Truck Affidavit was used to document the inspection of the vehicles used to deliver finished goods to the customer.

Transport vehicles were required to be secured while in transit; inbound and outbound vehicles were secured with a traceable seal and transfer vehicles were locked. The loading docks were designed (dock cushions, overhangs, built-in dock plates) to minimize risk to materials when loading/unloading.

Ingredients, packaging, and products were at ambient temperature and did not require refrigerated or frozen conditions.

- 11.6.5.1** The practices applied during loading, transport, and unloading of food shall be documented, implemented, and designed to maintain appropriate storage conditions and product integrity. Foods shall be loaded, transported, and unloaded under conditions suitable to prevent cross-contamination.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.6.5.2** Vehicles (e.g., trucks/vans/containers) used for transporting food within the site and from the site shall be inspected prior to loading to ensure they are clean, in good repair, suitable for the purpose, and free from odors or other conditions that may impact negatively on the product.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.6.5.3** Vehicles (e.g., trucks/vans/containers) shall be secured from tampering using seals or other agreed-upon and acceptable devices or systems.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.6.5.4** Loading and unloading docks shall be designed to protect the product during loading and unloading. Loading practices shall be designed to minimize unnecessary exposure of the product to conditions detrimental to maintaining product and package integrity during loading and transport.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

11.6.5.5 Refrigerated units shall maintain the product at the required temperature. The unit's temperature settings shall be set, checked, and recorded before loading, and the product temperature shall be recorded at regular intervals during loading, as applicable.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

11.6.5.6 The refrigeration unit shall be operational at all times and checks completed of the unit's operation, the door seals, and the storage temperature at regular intervals during transit.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

11.6.5.7 On arrival, prior to opening the doors, the food transport vehicle's refrigeration unit's storage temperature settings and operating temperature shall be checked and recorded. Unloading shall be completed efficiently, and product temperatures shall be recorded at the start of unloading and regular intervals during unloading.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

11.6.5.8 Unloading practices shall be designed to minimize unnecessary exposure of the product to conditions detrimental to maintaining product and package integrity.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

11.7.1 High-Risk Processes

The products were RTE nut products with a water activity <0.65. Risks were divided and maintained separation from raw peanuts. Tree nuts were pasteurized or irradiated prior to accepting.
Ambient air was tested for APC annually at each plant. The last tests were completed 1/10/2024 and 1/12/2024 with results through the air tester (1000L) each less than 5 cfu/m2.
Workers on the raw side had special colored hair nets and smocks that were not allowed in other areas of the facility. An ante room was used between the RTE and raw peanut areas.
Transfer points on products were roasters. These were designed to receive the raw peanuts on one side and unload the cooled/heat-treated product on the other.

11.7.1.1 The processing of high-risk food shall be conducted under controlled conditions, such that sensitive areas, in which the high-risk food has undergone a "kill" step, a "food safety intervention" or is subject to post-process handling, are protected/segregated from other processes, raw materials, or staff who handle raw materials, to ensure cross-contamination is minimized.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

11.7.1.2 Ambient air in high-risk areas shall be tested at least annually to confirm that it does not pose a risk to food safety.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.7.1.3** Areas in which high-risk processes are conducted shall only be serviced by staff dedicated to that function.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.7.1.4** Staff engaged in high-risk areas shall change into clean clothing and footwear or temporary protective outerwear when entering high-risk areas. Staff access points shall be located, designed, and equipped to enable staff to change into the distinctive protective clothing and practice a high standard of personal hygiene to prevent product contamination.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.7.1.5** Product transfer points shall be located and designed, so they do not compromise high-risk segregation and minimize the risk of cross-contamination.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

11.7.2 Thawing of Food

The food was not thawed.

11.7.3 Control of Foreign Matter Contamination

Operations had responsibility for preventing foreign material contamination, including equipment inspections, magnet inspections, and metal detector checks.

Other than finished product jars, glassware and ceramics were not allowed in production rooms.

The Glass Brittle Plastic policy had been last reviewed on 4/14/2024. The policy required an annual audit on total units and facilities. High risk areas (within the filling cabinets) required inspection as part of the shift pre-ops (listed on electronic inspection forms).

The Policy included a Glass/Brittle Plastic Clean-Up procedure under the responsibility of Operations. 28 breakages have occurred in the past year (due to the process of packaging the majority of products were in glass jars). Records were captured electronically in the QA software and included detailed clean-up steps. These forms were required to be verified by a Level 3 Supervisor of QA to close out after the inspections had been completed. The Annual Audits were conducted room by room and were detailed to the lighting, wall units, mezzanine, silos, and control buttons on each equipment. Inspections reviewed included the Almond Room (12/20/2023), Cashew Room (12/18/2023) and Peanut Processing Room (1/31/2023).

No true glass was used on processing equipment.

Wood pallets were inspected prior to being brought into packaging areas. Pallets observed during the audit were clean and in good condition.

Knives were issued and inspected by QA (software).

Gaskets and other wear items (pumps) were included in the PM program and verified during the audit.

- 11.7.3.1** The responsibility and methods used to prevent foreign matter contamination of the product shall be documented, implemented, and communicated to all staff.
Inspections shall be performed (refer to 2.5.4.3) to ensure plant and equipment remain in good condition and equipment has not become detached or deteriorated and is free from potential contaminants.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.7.3.2** Containers, equipment, and other utensils made of glass, porcelain, ceramics, laboratory glassware, or other similar materials shall not be permitted in food processing /contact zones (except where the product is contained in packaging made from these materials, or measurement instruments with glass dial covers are used, or MIG thermometers are required under regulation).
Where glass objects or similar material are required in food handling/contact zones, they shall be listed in a glass inventory, including details of their location and condition.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.7.3.3** Regular inspections of food handling/contact zones shall be conducted (refer to 2.5.4.3) to ensure they are free of glass or other like material and to establish changes to the condition of the objects listed in the glass inventory.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.7.3.5** In circumstances where glass or similar material breakage occurs, the affected area shall be isolated, cleaned, thoroughly inspected (including cleaning equipment and footwear), and cleared by a suitably responsible person prior to the start of operations.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.7.3.6** Wooden pallets and other wooden utensils used in food processing and handling areas shall be dedicated for that purpose, clean, and maintained in good order. Their condition shall be subject to regular inspection.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.7.3.7** Loose metal objects on equipment, equipment covers, and overhead structures shall be removed or tightly fixed so as not to present a hazard.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.7.3.8** Knives and cutting instruments used in processing and packaging operations shall be controlled, kept clean, and well maintained. Snap-off blades shall not be used in manufacturing or storage areas.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.7.3.9** Gaskets, rubber impellers, and other equipment made of materials that can wear or deteriorate over time shall be inspected on a regular frequency (refer to 2.5.4.3).

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

11.7.4 Detection of Foreign Objects

Magnets were inspected daily by operators and recorded in the QA software system and a review of completed magnet checks for the last three months was completed during the audit. The log highlighted in red any abnormal findings with no abnormal findings being recorded (abnormal findings provided an auto-alert to QA management). The checks were conducted at the same time as sifter screen checks. A sifter check from 4/4/2024 showed very fine plastic shavings that were captured, but QA provided evidence the CAPA had been investigated and resolved.

Metal detectors were checked by packaging operators every two hours. Most metal detectors were flow through detectors prior to packaging. One case metal detector was used for non-butter type products (boxed peanuts, boxed tree nuts). QA conducted line checks in each production room each day. The purpose of these checks was to make sure the CCP/Preventive Control checks were effective and that paperwork to that time was being completed, as required.

Potential foreign materials required products to be placed on Hold for QA disposition.

- 11.7.4.1** The responsibility, methods, and frequency for monitoring, maintaining, calibrating, and using screens, sieves, filters, or other technologies to remove or detect foreign matter shall be documented and implemented.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.7.4.2** Where detection and/or removal systems are used, the site shall establish limits for detection, based on a risk assessment of the product and its packaging, and identify the location(s) of the detector(s) in the process.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.7.4.3** Metal detectors or other physical contaminant detection technologies shall be routinely monitored, validated, and verified for operational effectiveness. The equipment shall be designed to isolate defective product and indicate when it is rejected.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.7.4.4** Records shall be maintained of the inspection of foreign object detection devices, of any products rejected or removed by them, and of corrective and preventative actions resulting from the inspections.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.7.4.5** In all cases of foreign matter contamination, the affected batch or item shall be isolated, inspected, reworked, or disposed of. Records shall be maintained of the disposition.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

11.8.1 Waste Disposal

QMS-PLC0036 described the procedures the site used to manage their processing waste. A licensed contractor conducted twice-weekly pick-up from outside closed-top dumpsters to prevent excessive accumulation. Waste disposal areas were located in secured areas of the facility. The waste bins and equipment were maintained clean and in serviceable condition to prevent the attraction of pests and other vermin. Inedible waste, including butters contained in lined box and peanut skins collected in bulk containers, were stored and handled for animal feed and kept separate from other storage or processing. Waste water (sanitation) was collected via the floor drainage system and discharged to the municipal sewerage system. Screens were used to capture solids in the wastewater. The manufacturing facilities were primarily dry processing areas; water was only introduced to the areas during wet cleaning activities. Line audits, GMP audits, and pre-operational inspections were utilized to review the effectiveness of waste management program. Trademarked materials were destroyed prior to disposal.

- 11.8.1.1** The responsibility and methods used to collect and handle dry, wet, and liquid waste and how to store it prior to removal from the premises shall be documented and implemented.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.8.1.2** Waste shall be removed on a regular basis and not allowed to build up in food handling or processing areas. Designated waste accumulation areas shall be maintained in a clean and tidy condition until external waste collection is undertaken.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.8.1.3** Waste and overflow water from tubs, tanks, and other equipment shall be discharged directly to the floor drainage system or by an alternative method that meets local regulatory requirements.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.8.1.4** Trolleys, vehicle waste disposal equipment, collection bins, and storage areas shall be maintained in a serviceable condition, cleaned, and sanitized regularly to prevent the attraction of pests and other vermin.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.8.1.5** Adequate provision shall be made for the disposal of all solid processing waste, including trimmings, inedible material, and used packaging.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.8.1.6** Where applicable, a documented procedure shall be in place for the controlled disposal of trademarked materials waste considered high-risk for handling or other reasons. Where a contracted disposal service is used, the disposal process shall be reviewed regularly to confirm compliance.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.8.1.7** Inedible waste designated for animal feed shall be stored and handled so that it will not cause a risk to the animal or further processing. If denaturant is used to identify inedible waste, it shall be demonstrated that it does not pose a risk to animal health.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.8.1.8** Waste held on-site prior to disposal shall be stored in a separate storage facility that is suitably insect proofed and located where it does not present any hazards.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.8.1.9** Adequate provision shall be made for the disposal of all liquid waste from processing and food handling areas. Liquid waste shall either be removed from the processing environment continuously or held in a designated storage area in lidded containers prior to disposal where it does not present any hazards.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE:

- 11.8.1.10** Reviews of the effectiveness of waste management shall form part of regular site inspections (refer to 2.5.4.3), and the results of these inspections shall be included in the relevant inspection reports.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE: